

Delhi Police reshuffle: 50 IPS, 20 DANIPS officers transferred

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police on Tuesday saw a major reshuffle in the brass, with the city Government ordering the transfer and posting of 50 IPS and 20 DANIPS officers across key positions with immediate effect, according to an official order.

The order, issued with the approval of the Lieutenant Governor, effected changes at levels including that of special commissioners, joint commissioners, additional commissioners and Deputy Commissioners of Police

(DCPs), impacting district policing, crime, traffic, security and specialised units.

Among senior-level changes, Sanjay Kumar Jain has been posted as the Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to the Commissioner of Police, with the additional charge of Joint Commissioner of Police (Tech and PI), while Joint Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Kime Kamjing has been appointed as the Joint CP (Armed Police).

Dheeraj Kumar moves from the post of Joint CP (Armed Police) to the position of Joint CP (Crime), heading the Anti-Narcotics Task Force

(ANTF). Ajit Kumar Singla has been posted as the Joint CP (Eastern Range), and Sanjay Kumar Tyagi takes over as the Joint CP (Traffic).

At the additional commissioner level, Monika Bhardwaj has been shifted from traffic to the position of Additional CP (IFSO), while Vijyanta Arya has been posted as the Additional CP (Traffic). Satya Vir Katara has been given the charge of the Additional CP (Recruitment) and Nidhin Valsan moves to the position of Additional CP (Tech and PI). Abhishek Dhania has been posted as the Additional CP (Crime-ANTF).

Several district-level



changes were also announced. Sachin Sharma, who was serving as the DCP (Outer) will take charge as the DCP (New Delhi), while DCP (Traffic) Shashank Jaiswal has been moved to the post of DCP (Rohini). Rajiv Kumar has been posted as the DCP (East) and Kushal Pal Singh as the DCP (Dwarka).

Rajendra Prasad Meena has been posted as the DCP (Shahdara) while Akanksha Yadav has been transferred as the DCP (North-West). Vikram Singh has been posted as the DCP (Outer) and Anant Mittal as the DCP (South). Rohit Rajbir Singh has taken over as the

DCP (Central). Several units also saw a shuffle, with Ankit Chauhan, who was serving as the DCP (South) being posted as the DCP (Special Branch) and Ankit Kumar Singh, who was the DCP (Dwarka), has been given the post of DCP (Vigilance). Shobhit D Saxena has been posted as the DCP (Traffic), while Bharat Reddy Bommarreddy takes charge as the DCP (Railways), with the additional charge of DCP (Metro).

Among other key postings, Sudhanshu Verma has been appointed as the DCP (Security-PM), Sandeep Gupta as the DCP (Traffic), Vineet Kumar as

the DCP (Tech and PI) and Sumit Kumar Jha as the DCP (CP's Secretariat-Crime). In the DANIPS cadre, multiple ACPs have been assigned additional DCP responsibilities in current duty-charge arrangements across districts including Shahdara, North, Outer, South-East and Rohini, as part of the wider administrative exercise.

The reshuffle also includes the transfer of senior Indian Police Service (IPS) officers Virender Singh to the position of DG (Home Guards), Anand Mohan to the post of DG (Prisons) and Surendra Singh Yadav to the position of DG (Civil Defence).

CM Rekha extends Holi greetings to Delhi residents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday extended Holi greetings to the people of the national Capital, calling the festival a symbol of harmony, unity and shared cultural heritage. She said the colours of Holi should blend with Delhi's development and spirit of brotherhood.

In her message on the eve of Holi, the Chief Minister said the festival is not just about colours but about strengthening social bonds. She wished peace, prosperity and happiness for every resident of the city.

Describing Holi as a celebration of unity in diversity, the Chief Minister urged citizens to come together to eliminate hatred and build an inclusive society. She said the festival offers an opportunity to reinforce mutual respect and harmony among communities.

The Chief Minister also linked the festive spirit with her government's development agenda. She said that just as different colours come together to create beauty, the



Government is working to connect every corner of Delhi with modern infrastructure. She highlighted efforts to improve roads, transport systems and smart civic facilities across the city.

The Chief Minister reiterated that her government is committed to transforming Delhi's infrastructure to world-class standards. She said steps are being taken to ensure seamless transport and better urban amenities. The Government, she added, is also implementing strong measures to control pollution and improve the quality of life.

Expressing confidence in

the vision of a 'Viksit Delhi', the Chief Minister said visible changes are underway, and the city is moving steadily towards becoming a model Capital. She said every citizen will take pride in the transformation. Appealing for responsible celebrations, the Chief Minister urged people to opt for an environmentally friendly Holi. She encouraged the use of natural colours and called upon residents to celebrate the festival with care for the environment.

She emphasised that fraternity remains Delhi's greatest strength. As the Capital of India, she said, Delhi's culture

sets an example for the rest of the country. A united and responsible citizenry is essential for sustained progress.

The Chief Minister said her Government remains dedicated to building a safe and prosperous Delhi. She added that development and social harmony must go hand in hand.

Concluding her message, the Chief Minister extended her best wishes for a peaceful and joyous Holi. She expressed confidence that the people of Delhi, united in spirit, will work together to realise the dream of a developed and inclusive Capital.

Tight vigil at Delhi borders ahead of Holi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national Capital will witness intensified vigil at all motorable Delhi-Haryana and Delhi-Uttar Pradesh borders, as part of the elaborate security arrangements to ensure peaceful celebrations. More than 15,000 police personnel will be deployed across the national Capital for Holi, an official said.

The deployment comes alongside a pre-Holi crack-down under 'Operation Aaghat', during which the southern range of Delhi Police arrested 204 people and apprehended 973 others under preventive provisions, according to the official.

Special focus this year will remain on drunken driving, rash driving and motorcycle stunts, with multiple pickets to be set up at major inter-sections, sensitive locations, markets and residential colonies. "Intensive checking will be conducted at all motorable borders with Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. Strategic barricading and naka picketing have been planned, and high-visibility policing will be maintained



throughout the festival period," a senior police officer said.

Traffic police teams equipped with breath analysers and speed detection devices will conduct day-long drives to identify and prosecute violators. Data shared by police show a steady rise in drunken driving cases over the past three years on the day of the festival — 559 in 2023, 824 in 2024 and 1,213 in 2025.

Action will also be taken against triple riding, over-speeding and performing wheelies or other stunts on two-wheelers, officials said. Cases of riding without helmets on Holi stood at 3,410 in 2023, 1,524 in 2024 and 2,376 in 2025.

Under Operation Aaghat, launched across South and Southeast districts, police carried out an intelligence-based synchronised crack-down on habitual offenders, bootleggers, drug peddlers, property offenders and other 'bad characters', they said.

Of the 204 arrests made under various provisions of the BNS, Arms Act, NDPS Act, Delhi Excise Act and Public Gambling Act, four proclaimed offenders and 29 bad characters were held, police said.

In southeast Delhi alone, 137 accused were arrested and 449 persons apprehended under preventive sections. One proclaimed offender was nabbed, 63

challans were issued under the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act, ₹11,500 were collected as fine, and 273 vehicles were deposited under the Delhi Police Act. In the South district, 67 people were arrested and 524 apprehended preventively. Police also arrested three proclaimed offenders and 29 habitual offenders during the drive.

Recoveries during the operation included 12 illegal firearms, 14 live cartridges, 24 knives, 7.197 kg of cannabis, 12.7 grams of MDMA and 15,945 quarters of illicit liquor. Police also seized ₹84,740 in gambling cases and recovered 18 stolen or lost mobile phones. One auto-lifter was arrested, and nine stolen motorcycles were recovered.

More than 350 personnel participated in the synchronised action across sensitive pockets, officials said, adding that women police personnel are also being deployed at key locations. Police have appealed to citizens to celebrate Holi responsibly, avoid forceful colouring and refrain from creating a nuisance in public places.

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IN FOCUS



An effigy of Holiika is burned as part of rituals ahead of the 'Holi' festival, in Patna, late Monday, March 2, 2026

PTI

NDMC declares Palika Dham complex unsafe



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ NEW DELHI

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Tuesday declared the Palika Dham Complex (Type-I quarters) at Gole Market in central Delhi structurally unsafe and asked residents to vacate it. In a public notice issued by the council's Housing Department, the authority said the complex was in a dilapidated condition and unsafe for habitation.

The advisory said the step was taken to prevent any untoward incident, accident or loss of life. Officials said that in September 2025, the council had given a notice to the residents to vacate the housing premises. "There are at least 149 residential quarters, most of which have been vacated. Around 40 families are still living there ã, most of them have been allotted housing via a lottery system," an NDMC official said.

The NDMC has urged all allottees and occupants to cooperate with the administration and immediately begin vacating the premises. "Residents have been asked to complete the process by March 7, 2026, to avoid risks to human life," it said. Earlier in July last year, the NDMC declared the buildings unsafe and asked residents to vacate their homes. In a notice issued on July 11, residents were directed to register their names and details on the NDMC's e-Awas Portal between July 14 and 16 to apply for alternative housing.

Verification of these applications was to be completed by July 17. The announcement has left residents divided - all of whom are Government employees, both retired and currently serving. Pointing to a broken window in her

flat from the road, an employee with the NDMC's health department had said, "They are asking us to vacate for a valid reason. What if an accident takes place? Who will be responsible?"

She had said that a month ago, her sister-in-law suffered injuries to her back after plaster from the ceiling at her home fell on her. "Moving and shifting the children to other schools will be a hassle, but it is better than living with a daily risk." She had added that the water tankers located above the homes have caused seepage and weakened the ceilings.

Since the 1970s, the complex has been home to more than a hundred Government employees, said residents. It also includes a gym, a temple, and a baraat-ghar (wedding hall).

The RWA had submitted a letter to the New Delhi Assembly constituency MLA, Parvesh Sahib Singh, requesting him to solve the problems faced by residents. Their concerns include broken hand-pumps, lack of security guards, overgrown trees, and leakage in water pipelines.

"The NDMC places the highest priority on the safety and welfare of its employees. After a detailed structural assessment, the Palika Dham flats, which are more than 50 years old and have outlived their lifespan, were declared unsafe for habitation. The safety of residents cannot be compromised under any circumstances.

However, regular maintenance of these flats was being carried out by the council," an official had said. The official added that the civic body has taken proactive steps to ensure that affected residents are offered new, suitable and more spacious alternative accommodations.

BJP announces candidates for Rajya Sabha elections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Patna

The BJP on Tuesday released a list of nine candidates for the upcoming Rajya Sabha polls. The party will field BJP president Nitin Nabin, who currently holds the Bankipur Assembly seat in Bihar, along with Shivesh Kumar, a former MLA who had unsuccessfully contested the Sasaram Lok Sabha seat in the general elections held two years ago, its former West Bengal unit chief Rahul Sinha and Chhattisgarh unit vice-president Laxmi Verma from the respective States.

The biennial polls to 37 Rajya Sabha seats across 10 states that are falling vacant on different dates in April are set to be held on March 16.



BJP National President Nitin Nabin with Bihar party President Sanjay Saraogi with others during Holi Milan Samaroh in Patna

PTI

The counting of votes will take place the same day. The States where the seats are falling vacant are Maharashtra (seven), Odisha (four), Telangana (two), Tamil Nadu (six), Chhattisgarh (two), West Bengal (five), Assam (three), Haryana (two), Himachal Pradesh (one) and

Bihar (five). The last date for filing nominations is March 5. Assam PWD Minister Jogen Mohan and MLA TerashGowalla will be the saffron party's candidates from the state for the election to the Upper House of Parliament. The BJP has also nominated its Odisha unit

president, Manmohan Samal, and leader Sujeet Kumar, an incumbent Rajya Sabha MP, as candidates from the state for the upcoming polls.

BJP leader Shivesh Kumar will join the fray from Bihar and Sanjay Bhatia, a former Lok Sabha MP of the party, will be its candidate from Haryana. Kumar is Bihar BJP's general secretary.

The names of the candidates have been approved by the party's central election committee, BJP national general secretary Arun Singh said.

Nabin's nomination for the Rajya Sabha polls from Bihar was expected since he was elected unopposed as the BJP's 12th national president in January.

Boy dies in accidental firing at birthday party

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow



A 13-year-old boy was killed allegedly in firing during a birthday party in the Krishna Nagar area of Lucknow, police said on Tuesday.

The incident took place around 6.40 pm on Monday at an LDA Colony residence under the Krishna Nagar police station limits.

The victim, Unais Khan, had gone to attend a friend's birthday party at his house with three other minors. During the celebration, Navneet Tripathi, the birthday boy aged 13, allegedly took out his father's licensed revolver from a car parked outside and accidentally fired it, the police said.

The bullet hit Unais above his left eye, and he collapsed on the floor. He was rushed

to Lokbandhu Hospital, where doctors declared him dead. His family alleged that Unais was shot by an adult and it was no accidental fire. Deputy Commissioner of Police (Lucknow South) Nipun Agarwal said the three minors present at the party have been taken into custody and are being questioned.

"On March 2, information was received at Krishna Nagar police station that a 13-year-old boy, Unais Khan, a resident of Transport Nagar, had died due to accidental firing while attending a birthday party with his friends.

Delhi Police refers defence entrepreneur's threat complaint to Special Cell

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has taken cognisance of a complaint filed by a defence entrepreneur alleging fresh death threats from an international extortion network and referred the matter to its Special Cell, an official said on Tuesday.

According to a written complaint submitted at Chanakyapuri police station on February 27 by Sahil Luthra, Managing Director of Vijayan Trishul Defence Solutions (VTDS), he received two threatening calls on February 26 from international numbers, including those bearing country codes of Portugal and Germany. In his complaint, Luthra alleged that the callers



claimed responsibility for a firing incident that took place outside his residence in Amritsar on the intervening night of November 29 and 30 last year.

The callers warned him of escalated action, stating that future attacks would directly target him, he said. According to the complaint, the callers also claimed they were

aware of the security cover provided to him and asserted that such protection would not prevent an attack.

In an email response to Luthra, the Office of the Commissioner of Police acknowledged receipt of his communication and informed him that the matter had been referred to the Special Commissioner of Police, Special Cell, for further necessary action.

Luthra told police he had been receiving threats since October 2024, around the time his company announced expansion plans in Punjab. He alleged that in August 2025, he was asked to pay 70 crore. Investigators are examining whether the demand and the pattern of intimidation bear simi-

larities to other high-profile extortion cases reported in recent months, officials said. The complaint states that the threatening communications were routed through VoIP calls and traced to multiple countries, including Portugal, Germany, Canada and the United States. Cyber units are analysing the technical trail to ascertain the origin and authenticity of the calls, sources added. Luthra further referred to mentions of the banned outfit Babbar Khalsa International (BKI) and gangster Goldy Brar in the threatening communications. However, investigating agencies have not publicly confirmed any direct organisational involvement and said the claims are being verified as part of

the ongoing probe. The firing incident at his Amritsar residence is already under investigation by Punjab Police. No arrests have been made so far.

In his complaint, Luthra also alleged that his company faced attempted cyber intrusions in May 2025 targeting its official email accounts and social media handles, with some of the digital activity appearing to originate from overseas accounts. These aspects are also under examination, officials said. Law enforcement agencies are assessing possible cross-border linkages, particularly the use of international communication channels and internet-based calling platforms. Further investigation is underway, they added.

Congress releases first list of 42 candidates for Assam Assembly polls

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Congress on Tuesday released its first list of 42 candidates for the upcoming Assam Assembly polls, fielding state party chief Gaurav Gogoi from the Jorhat seat. Taking a lead in announcing the names of its candidates even before the declaration of the polls, the opposition party said Congress Legislature Party leader in Assam Debabrata Saikia will contest the election from the Nazira constituency.

Former PCC president Ripun Bora has been fielded from the Barchalla constituency. According to the



Baruah from Bongaigaon and Mahananda Sarkar from Barpeta (reserved for Scheduled Caste candidates).

Ramen Singh Rabha will be the party candidate from the Boko-Chaygaon (ST) seat, Nandita Das from Hajo-Sualkuchi (SC) and Satyabrata Kalita from Kamalpur. Mira Borthakur Goswami has been fielded from Dispur, while Diganta Barman will be the party candidate from Barkhetri and Ashok Kumar Sarma from Nalbari.

The polls for the 126-member Assam Assembly are likely to be held in April. The Congress has been out of power in the northeastern state since 2016.

HP Govt disbursed ₹17 crore for welfare of ex-servicemen

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu announced on Tuesday that financial assistance exceeding Rs 17 crore has been provided to ex-servicemen, gallantry award winners, and the families of martyrs in the state during the current financial year.

A sum of over ₹17 crore has been disbursed to 2,263 beneficiaries under various welfare schemes, and 968 elderly pensioners have received ₹6.12 crore to ensure financial security and dignified living, the chief minister said in a statement issued here.

Additionally, 1,084 gal-



lanty award winners have received honorariums amounting to ₹ 3 crore in recognition of their exemplary courage and service to the nation.

He further shared that ₹7.62 crore has been extended to 57 dependents of defence personnel who were martyred or disabled in action, while an amount

of ₹20.83 lakh has also been disbursed to 154 war Jagir beneficiaries as part of the Government's continued welfare initiatives.

"The ex-servicemen of the state and their families are invaluable assets whose unparalleled contribution and supreme sacrifices in safeguarding the nation will always be remembered

with gratitude and pride," the chief minister said.

Highlighting the Government's efforts to inspire the youth, Sukhu said that a budget of ₹ 2.28 crore has been sanctioned for organising army recruitment rallies in Kangra, Mandi, Hamirpur and Shimla districts. This initiative aims to strengthen the patriotic spirit among young people and encourage them to pursue careers in the armed forces.

Expressing pride in the state's distinguished legacy, he remarked, "It is a matter of honour for a small state like Himachal Pradesh to have four Param Vir Chakra awardees." Sukhu empha-

sised that the valour and sacrifices of Himachali soldiers stand as a testament to their deep sense of duty and patriotism.

The chief minister also informed that ₹10.26 crore has been earmarked for the financial year 2025-26 to strengthen and expand the Major Somnath Training Academy at Barchhwar in Mandi district. Major Somnath Sharma was the first recipient of the Param Vir Chakra from Himachal.

The academy plays a pivotal role in providing quality and competitive training to youth, enabling them to prepare effectively for recruitment into the armed forces.

Judicial delays: Experts push for Satyug bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With nearly 5 crore cases pending across courts in India, legal experts have raised concerns that structural issues within the justice



delivery system continue to contribute significantly to judicial delays. The issue was highlighted at a press conference held at the Press Club of India in Delhi, where speakers strongly advocated for the introduction of a proposed "Satyug Bill."

The proposed legislation seeks to restore the sanctity of sworn testimony and ensure stringent consequences for those who deliberately mislead the judicial system. The experts emphasised that while increasing judicial appointments and digitising courts are helpful, the real challenge lies in holding individuals accountable for false statements under oath.

They argued that without strict action, court backlogs will persist. The issue has already been raised in Parliament and the Supreme Court. Petitioner Ashwini Upadhyay stated that the primary reason behind mounting pendency is the lack of punishment for those filing false complaints.

India moves students in Iran, ships put on alert

Shipping companies have also been advised to exercise due caution in crew deployment and to maintain regular communication with seafarers and their families. The Directorate said a dedicated 'quick response team' has also been formed to ensure timely coordination among all concerned authorities, enable immediate response to emerging situations, and facilitate prompt assistance and support to Indian seafarers and their families.

PM Modi urges industry to seize FTA...

'Our direction is clear. Our resolve is clear. Build more, produce more, connect more, and now the need is to export more,' he said.

He urged participants at the webinar to prioritise key issues such as ways to increase man-

ufacturing and production, make cost structures more competitive, accelerate investment flows, and ensure that development reaches every corner of the country. Stressing that manufacturing, logistics, MSMEs, small and cottage industries, and even small and large cities appear as separate pillars of the economy, he said they are all interconnected.

"Strong manufacturing creates new opportunities and boosts exports. Competitive MSMEs promote flexibility and innovation. Better logistics reduce costs. Well-planned cities attract both investment and talent. This year's budget has strengthened all these pillars significantly," he said. Observing that the reforms made in MSME classification have had a wide impact, he said, 'enterprises no longer fear that expanding their business will deprive them of government benefits. Continuous efforts have been made to improve MSMEs' access to credit, promote technology upgrades, and build capacity.'

However, he said, the real impact of these efforts will be visible only when MSMEs actively participate in competition with the aim of

winning. Now is the time for MSMEs to increase productivity, raise quality standards, adopt digital processes, and integrate into strong value chains. Your suggestions in this direction will be extremely important, he added.

Highlighting the importance of infrastructure and logistics, he said, they serve as fundamental pillars of our growth strategy.

This year's budget proposes a record level of capital expenditure to support these priorities, he said.

PM Modi dials Gulf as 149 Indians return home

The flight marked the first international arrival by an Indian carrier into the Capital since services were disrupted.

Inside the arrivals terminal, scenes of reunion unfolded quietly but powerfully. Families embraced. Some passengers wiped away tears. Others appeared drained after days of uncertainty in a region where missile strikes and airspace

closures had upended travel plans overnight.

"We were watching the news constantly. Every day of delay meant more hotel bills. It was mentally and financially stressful," said a tourist from the Noida, expressing gratitude to Indian authorities and the airline for arranging the return. Several passengers described a tense but controlled atmosphere on the ground in Dubai. One traveller recalled hearing emergency sirens but said there were no direct incidents in her vicinity. 'Security was strong. The situation felt stable, but the uncertainty about flights made everyone anxious,' she said.

Operations resumed in a limited capacity at Dubai's two main airports late on March 2, allowing restricted outbound movement. That partial reopening offered hope to thousands of foreign nationals stranded across the Gulf as commercial aviation across much of West Asia remained suspended or severely restricted.

The disruption was not confined to the UAE. Indians returning from Muscat in Oman described a comparatively calm environment but similar travel chaos. Flights were suspend-

ed for roughly 24 hours, affecting multiple carriers. 'Life around us felt normal,' said one passenger. 'But when flights stop, you suddenly feel cut off from home.'

Another returnee, Mohammad Idris, said Muscat remained peaceful and comparable to daily life in Delhi, though uncertainty over flight schedules created concern among expatriates.

The human dimension of the crisis extends beyond tourists. Millions of Indian nationals live and work across the Gulf, forming one of the world's largest expatriate communities.

The United States has also advised its citizens in multiple Middle Eastern countries to depart if commercial options are available, reflecting the broader international concern over the deteriorating security environment.

For now, as limited flights resume and governments scramble to assist nationals abroad, the scenes at Delhi's airport capture the emotional toll of geopolitical conflict on ordinary lives. For those who have returned, relief outweighs fear - but uncertainty still hangs over the region they left behind.

FROM PAGE - 1

JD(U) celebrates as Nishant Kumar enters politics

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar has done away with his aversion for “dynasty politics”, and agreed on Tuesday to launch his only son Nishant in politics, a development that led to jubilations in the JD(U) and triggered speculation of a Rajya Sabha berth for the scion.

The announcement came from State Rural Development Minister and senior party leader Shrawon Kumar, who has been a close aide of the JD(U) supremo since the Samata Party days, in the 1990s.

“On the eve of Holi, I have some good news to share with the people of Bihar. It has been some time since there have been demands, from within the JD(U) as well as from among the State’s

youth, that Nishant, the son of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, join politics. Decks have been cleared for that and a formal announcement will be made in a day or two,” Shrawon Kumar said.

When he was asked whether the JD(U) supremo’s son, an engineering graduate who is in his 40s, could be one of the two party candidates for the biennial Rajya Sabha elections, the JD(U) leader replied, “Anything is possible. All would be made known in a day or two after top party leaders sit down to discuss these things.”

As soon as the news spread, celebrations erupted at the JD(U)’s State headquarters here, the walls of which have for some time been adorned with posters demanding that the supreme leader’s son take over the reins from his father.



Party workers distributed sweets, smeared each other’s faces with ‘gulaal’ and raised slogans to express their delight over the imminent political entry of their supremo’s son.

“It is great news. Nishant is adored by the people of Bihar who are impressed with his graceful conduct in public. He is an engineer like his father whom he resembles in many other respects,” State

minister and JD(U) national general secretary Ashok Choudhary said. Bristling at the suggestion that the son’s political entry could raise questions about Nitish Kumar’s public posturing on “dynasty politics”, Choudhary said, “Our leader is not imposing on the party an offspring who does not have the required competence. Nishant has all the makings of a good leader and it was the party that wanted him to be in public life.” Not much is known about the reclusive son of Bihar’s longest chief minister, who is a bachelor and is said to have few interests besides spirituality and listening to devotional songs.

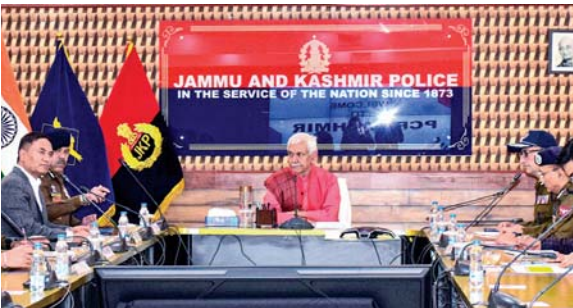
On the rare occasions that he is seen in public, Nishant has endeared himself to the people by his humility. Also, while interacting with the media, he has given glimpses

of the close track he keeps of the good work done by his father. Allies also welcomed the development. Former State BJP president and minister Dilip Jaiswal said, “If Nitish Kumar’s son enters politics, it will be great. It is time for a new generation of leaders to emerge.”

Rumours were afloat that on Thursday, a day after Holi and the last date for filing of nomination papers for Rajya Sabha polls, a function will be held at the JD(U) office where Nishant will be formally inducted into the party.

Altogether five Rajya Sabha seats from Bihar are going to polls in the biennial elections and the BJP, which is the single-largest party in the State assembly with 89 MLAs, is contesting two of these, its other candidate being former legislator and Dalit leader Shivesh Kumar.

LG Manoj Sinha orders heightened alert across J&K



J and K LG Manoj Sinha chairs a meeting of senior police and civil administration officials to review the law and order situation at the Police Control Room in Srinagar

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Even as the overall law and order situation remained peaceful across Jammu and Kashmir, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Tuesday directed police and civil administration officials to remain on heightened alert and take all necessary steps to maintain peace and tranquillity.

The Lieutenant Governor also held closed-door deliberations on the prevailing security scenario with Lt Gen Pratik Sharma, GoC-in-C, Northern Command, Nalin Prabhat, DGP, J&K, Lt Gen Prashant Srivastava, GoC 15 Corps & Maj Gen Balbir Singh, MGGS, Northern Command, at Lok Bhavan, Srinagar.

The meeting was held in the wake of widespread protests in Kashmir and parts of the Jammu region against the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Srinagar police have taken serious cognisance of the deliberate circulation of false, fabricated and misleading information by certain news channels, media outlets, and individuals across electronic and social media platforms, a police spokesman said.

However, details of the media outlets and individuals were not immediately known.

The spokesman said these elements are “systematically attempting” to spread distorted narratives and unverified content with the clear intent to incite unrest, disturb public order, and create disharmony in society.

“Such malicious misinformation campaigns pose a grave threat to peace, security, and the integrity of the nation,” the spokesman said.

in a post on X. He appealed to the people and community leaders to uphold harmony and ensure that a calm atmosphere prevails. Meanwhile, a case was registered against some media outlets and individuals on Tuesday for allegedly circulating misleading information with the intention to incite unrest in connection with the protests against the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

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PM must speak up; does he support head of State’s assassination: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday urged industry leaders to step up investments, embrace emerging technologies and prioritise research to leverage the vast opportunities offered by free trade agreements with various nations.

Addressing the second webinar on Budget 2026-27, the prime minister said, the world is now looking for reliable and resilient manufacturing partners, and India has the opportunity to play this role decisively and enhance the country’s participation in the global supply chain. For this, he said, “all stakeholders must invest with confidence, adopt new technologies, and significantly increase investment in research — those days of



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi

being frugal in research are over. We must ensure quality in line with global standards. As I often say, when opportunities arise to move ahead, we must have only one mantra — Quality, Quality, Quality.”

Stressing that India has entered into free trade agreements with numerous countries, he said, these agreements have opened up a wide range of opportunities for the country.

BJP alleges ₹7 crore ‘ticket extortion’ bid by Gandhi family in Haryana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Tuesday cited a reported claim of a former Haryana Congress leader’s husband to allege that the Gandhi family tried to “extort” ₹7 crore from the couple in exchange for an Assembly poll ticket in the State.

BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari claimed that Gaurav Kumar, the husband of a former Haryana Mahila Congress general secretary, has made public WhatsApp chats involving personal assistants of senior Congress leaders, including Priyanka Gandhi Vadra. He described the chats as “prima-facie proof” of the Gandhi family’s “corruption”.

Bhandari, however, did not disclose the name of



Pradeep Bhandari

the former Haryana Mahila Congress leader or clarify whether the allegation pertained to the 2024 Assembly polls in the State. There was no immediate reaction from the Congress to the BJP’s charge.

Talking to reporters at the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) headquarters here, Bhandari said, “For the last few days, the country has been discussing how the Gandhi-Vadra family is compromised and corrupt. Today, we are presenting before you a

prima-facie proof of corruption by Priyanka Vadra, Rahul Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi.”

He claimed that Kumar has brought to light how the Gandhi family tried to extort ₹7 crore from the couple in exchange for giving his wife a party ticket from the Bawal Assembly seat.

“At a press conference, he (Kumar) has made public WhatsApp chats with the PAs (personal assistants) of Priyanka Vadra, KC Venugopal and K Suresh, exposing how the Gandhi family used Venugopal as a front to extort money from the former general secretary of the Haryana Mahila Congress,” Bhandari said.

He claimed that the Gandhi family’s silence on the issue is nothing but an “admission of guilt”. BJP’s Rajya Sabha MP Sudhanshu

Trivedi said Kumar’s claim “proves” that the Congress is “corrupt to the core”. Earlier, former Punjab Congress leader Navjot Kaur Sidhu had said at least an amount of ₹500 crore is needed for the chief minister’s post in the Congress, Trivedi, who is also a BJP spokesperson, said.

“Margaret Alva’s book says seats in Karnataka in 2008 were open to bid. Now this recent expose from Keralam (Kerala) proves that from Government to organisation and from Punjab to Keralam, the character of Congress is corrupt to the core,” he said in a post on X.

Trivedi claimed that a Malayalam television channel is in possession of WhatsApp chats of Congress leaders that corroborate the BJP’s allegations.

सत्यमेव जयते

दिल्ली सरकार

दिल्ली में भरने हैं

विकास

के रंग

Happy होली

Happy होली

आप सभी को होली की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं

यह पर्व आपके जीवन में सुख, समृद्धि और आनंद के नए रंग भरे

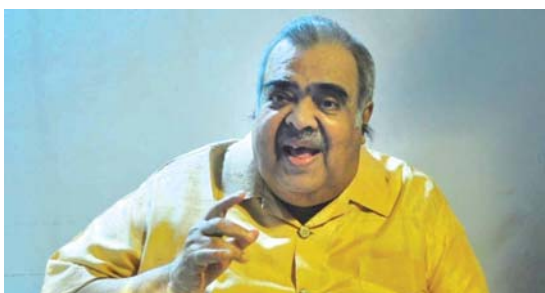
States Focus



LAST RITES OF DR JANARDAN WAGHMARE HELD IN LATUR

The last rites of renowned educationist and former Rajya Sabha member Dr Janardan Waghmare were performed at his village in Maharashtra's Latur district on Tuesday. State Minister Babasaheb Patil, Congress MLA Amit Deshmukh, NCP's Sanjay Bansode, MP Shivaji Kalge, among other senior politicians and officials, were present for the cremation held at Kavtha village in Ausa tehsil, 20 km from the district headquarters.

Waghmare (91) passed away after a brief illness at his residence in Latur on Monday. He was a close aide to NCP founder Sharad Pawar and had been widely acknowledged for his lifelong contribution to education, literature and public service.



FORMER UNION MINISTER KP UNNIKRISHNAN DIES AT 89

Former Union Minister KP Unnikrishnan, who was regarded as one of the prominent figures in Indian politics during the 1980s and 1990s, died in the early hours of Tuesday, his family said. He was 89. He died while undergoing treatment for age-related ailments at a private hospital here, they said.

Having been elected to the Lok Sabha six consecutive times from Vadakara, he served as a Union Minister in the VP Singh Cabinet, holding the portfolios of Surface Transport and Communications during 1989 to 90.

Siddaramaiah backs Tamil Nadu CM's call on Centre-State relations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has written to his counterpart in Tamil Nadu, MK Stalin, expressing the State's strong support for a renewed national discourse on Centre - State relations.

Siddaramaiah said he will urge the union Government to provide an institutional platform — such as a revitalised Inter-State Council — for all States to deliberate and restore balance in our federal structure.

Taking to social media platform 'X', the Karnataka CM said federalism is not a political demand — it is part of the basic structure of our Constitution.

"Over the years, increasing centralisation in fiscal and legislative matters has



Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah

disturbed the delicate balance envisioned by our Constitution makers. States must have the authority and fiscal space to fulfil the responsibilities entrusted to them. India's strength lies in cooperative federalism, constitutional trust, and respect for diversity," he said.

He assured that Karnataka stands ready to engage con-

structively in strengthening India's democratic and federal framework.

Siddaramaiah has written to the TN CM in response to Stalin's letter dated February 20, 2026, forwarding Part I of the report of the high-level committee on Union-State relations. In his letter dated March 2, Siddaramaiah acknowledged and appreci-

ated the initiative taken by the Tamil Nadu Government in initiating the report, which seeks "constitutional correction". Noting that the questions raised in the report go to the heart of India's constitutional morality, the chief minister said federalism was not an act of administrative convenience but a structural guarantee against concentration of power.

"Over the decades, however, a phenomenon of incremental centralisation has altered the federal balance through expansive interpretations of the Concurrent List, conditional fiscal transfers, centrally designed schemes with diminishing State flexibility, and procedural bottlenecks in governor's assent," Siddaramaiah said in the letter.

Punjab recovers ₹170 crore from pension fraud

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

Punjab Social Security Minister Baljit Kaur on Tuesday said her department recovered a sum of ₹170 crore which was being credited into the accounts of dead beneficiaries under the old age scheme.

Addressing the media here, Kaur said over 23.62 lakh eligible elderly beneficiaries under the old age pension scheme are getting ₹1,500 per month in a transparent manner.

She said her department has deleted accounts of dead beneficiaries under this scheme. "We recovered a sum of ₹170 crore which were going into the accounts of dead beneficiaries," she said,



Punjab Social Security Minister Baljit Kaur

adding regular monitoring of the scheme is being undertaken.

Sharing details of works done by Social Security, Women and Child Development, Social Justice, Empowerment and Minorities departments in the last four years, the minister had said that a sum of ₹3,806 crore was released under the old age pension

scheme during 2025-26. The minister also said that two old age homes have been set up in Tapa and Mansa at an outlay of ₹17.33 crore.

She further said her department also disbursed ₹11.43 crore of grants to social organisations which were running 'ashrams' for the elderly in the State.

She said the State Government has been providing free bus service to women and also said that a sum of ₹2,042 crore has been spent in this regard.

Besides, five hostels for working women are being set up in three districts — three in Mohali and one each in Amritsar and Jalandhar. There will also be creche facility for the children of women in these hostels, she said.

MSRTC to rake in ₹250 crore via ads

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

The Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC) will shore up its revenue through advertising and earn more than ₹250 crore over the next five years, Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik said on Tuesday.

The move aims to transform the State's iconic 'Lal Pari' (red buses) from a primary transport utility into a significant revenue-generating engine, the MSRTC chairman said during the 310th Board of Directors meeting held at the MSRTC headquarters.

According to a release issued by the MSRTC on Tuesday, Sarnaik Stated that an ambitious plan has been finalised to leverage the corporation's massive footprint.

"The ST Corporation has 251 depots and more than 610 bus stands spread across every corner of Maharashtra. With a fleet of about 12,000 buses transporting 50 to 55 lakh passengers daily, this is a golden

opportunity for advertisers," the minister said. As the fleet expands, daily ridership is expected to touch the 1-crore mark, significantly increasing the valuation of advertising space, he added.

"An ambitious plan has been prepared to increase advertising revenue by making full use of bus stands, their surroundings, and the interior and exterior of buses. A competitive bidding process has already been implemented, and bids worth more than ₹250 crore have been accepted for the next five years," Sarnaik said.

Currently, the MSRTC earns approximately ₹22 crore annually from advertisements. The new tenders are expected to more than double this yearly income. The rights will be transitioned to new licensees once the current contracts expire, according to the release.

Sarnaik expressed confidence that diversifying income streams is the only way to ensure the financial health of the State transport utility.



Manipur CM flags off national integration tour



Manipur CM Y Khemchand Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Imphal

Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Tuesday flagged off a national integration tour organised by the Assam Rifles for youths of the State.

Under the tour, 24 youths from various communities of Manipur will visit Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Kolkata and Mumbai, officials said. The tour was flagged off from Keithelmanbi.

Speaking at the ceremony, the chief minister expressed his gratitude to Assam Rifles for their continuous service to the State, especially for their humanitarian efforts in safely shifting over 47,000 people from both the Meitei and Kuki communities during times of unrest.

He further lauded the force for organising such initiatives that integrate the youths of the State and urged the elders of the State to forgive one another and guide the younger generation towards a harmonious and peaceful future. Participants will be visiting Trivandrum, Kanyakumari, Mumbai, and Kolkata during the tour.

Singh, in a post on X, said, "The national integration tour is a significant initiative aimed at fostering unity through exposure, understanding, and shared experiences. By visiting Kerala and Tamil Nadu, our youth will have the opportunity to witness the diverse cultural landscapes, developmental strides, and rich traditions that define the spirit of India." He said, "such initiatives broaden perspectives, nurture mutual respect, and strengthen the emotional bond that unites our great nation" and called for "young minds to appreciate diversity, embrace inclusivity, and contribute meaningfully to the continued progress and integration of India."

Shinde arranges two planes to bring back 164 people from UAE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde has arranged two aircraft to bring back 164 citizens of the State stranded in the United Arab Emirates amid the US-Israel-Iran conflict, his office informed on Tuesday. The State Government has also launched an emergency WhatsApp helpline for hundreds of State residents stranded in the Middle East. Shinde's office in a Statement said two flights will take off from Fujairah Airport at 3.30 pm and 4.30 pm and are expected to land in Mumbai in the evening. The 164 passengers include 84 students of the Pune-based Indira School of Business Studies and residents from Thane, Ahilyanagar and Pune, it Stated. The deputy chief minister has been in touch with those stranded since the West Asia conflict started on Saturday.

According to officials, several hundred people from Maharashtra are stranded in the Middle East due to airspace closure caused by the Iran war, though all are safe. The Chief Minister's Office (CMO), in a social media post said that CM Devendra Fadnis is personally monitoring the situation and is in constant contact with various agencies.



Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde

He is also coordinating regularly with the Central Government, which is extending all possible assistance, while Maharashtra Minister Girish Mahajan has been tasked with coordination efforts.

The CMO Stated that the State Government, in coordination with the Indian People's Forum in Dubai, has issued a WhatsApp helpline number +971 50 365 4357 for stranded citizens who require assistance. Figures of stranded citizens are being collected from more places across Maharashtra, officials have said.

Among those stranded in Dubai is the Congress's Jalna Lok Sabha MP Kalyan Kale, who had gone there on Friday, just a day before the joint US-Israel strike in Iran, his brother Jagannath Kale said.

Left parties to hold march to West Bengal CEO's office demanding correct voter list

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

CPI(M) West Bengal State secretary Mohammed Salim said that Left parties will organise a march to the West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office on Wednesday, demanding publication of a correct voter list before the upcoming assembly elections.

Citing large-scale harassment of the people because of the exercise, he claimed on Tuesday that the "Nirbachan (Election) Commission" has turned into a "Nirjatan (Torture) Commission".

The ECI published the post-SIR rolls on February 28, recording 63.66 lakh deletions, 8.3 per cent of the electorate, reducing the voter base to just over 7.04 crore ahead of assembly



CPI(M) West Bengal State secretary Mohammed Salim

polls. More than 60.06 lakh electors have also been placed in the "under adjudication" category, subject to scrutiny in the coming weeks.

"In the name of intensive revision of the voter list, a concerted conspiracy has taken place," Salim said, addressing a press conference at the CPI(M) office in Purba Bardhaman district. The CPI(M) leader Stated

that the constituents of the Left Front will hold a march to the CEO's office in Kolkata on Wednesday, demanding that the ECI publish a correct voter list before the assembly elections in West Bengal. He claimed that the ECI, the authority responsible for ensuring free and fair elections, has made the SIR process complex and brought about tensions in the minds of a large number

of people.

Salim maintained that there was no need for the SIR, while demanding that the ECI ensure that the names of genuine voters are not deleted from the electoral rolls.

Alleging harassment of people in the name of logical discrepancy in the SIR process in West Bengal, he Stated that this could have been largely avoided if the State Government had standardised name spellings by passing a resolution in the assembly.

The CPI(M) leader claimed that important issues affecting the general public, such as education and health-care, etc have been pushed to the back burner by both the Trinamool Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) through shadow boxing over religious issues.

Himachal Pradesh mandates EV charging stations in buildings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

The State Government has mandated the installation of Electric Vehicle (EV) charging stations across commercial, public, semi-public buildings and real estate projects under the Himachal Pradesh Town and Country Planning (17th Amendment) Rules, 2026, officials said on Tuesday.

The move has been aligned with model building bye-laws, which ensures the State's physical infrastructure evolves in tandem with the rising adoption of electric mobility. Town and Country Planning Minister Rajesh Dharmani said in a Statement issued here.



The Himachal Pradesh Government is committed to becoming a green energy State, and to realise this, decisive legislative updates have been integrated for

sustainable infrastructure into urban development, the minister added. Dharmani said that to further incentivise energy efficiency, the State Government has strict-

ly implemented the HP Energy Conservation Building Code (HPECBC) and Rules 2018. Under these regulations, specialised buildings including hospitality, health-care, educational and shopping complexes covering an area of 750 square metres or more would be granted an additional 0.25 Floor Area Ratio (FAR) over the base FAR of 1.75, provided they comply with energy conservation building code (ECBC) standards.

To ensure compliance, developers must now engage Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) authorised Energy Auditors to vet project designs and oversee construction phases before municipal authorities issue occupancy certificates.

Addressing the economic framework of urban expansion, Dharmani detailed the 18th Amendment Rules, 2026, which establish a structured fee for Premium FAR in real estate projects.

The newly defined rates range from ₹3,000 per square metre for up to 0.25 premium FAR, scaling to ₹7,000 for ratios exceeding 0.50.

These charges do not apply to previously completed projects with existing certificates; they would be mandatory for new blocks in ongoing developments and all upcoming real estate ventures, offering developers the flexibility to purchase additional FAR during the initial planning stages, the Statement added.

Army, Ladakh administration ink MoU to preserve fragile ecology, wildlife

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

The Army's Fire and Fury Corps and the Ladakh administration on Tuesday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) to preserve the fragile high-altitude ecology of the region and conserve key wildlife species, including the snow leopard, Himalayan wolf, ibex, marmot and black-necked crane.

The MoU was signed on the occasion of World Wildlife Day between the Army's Udhampur-based Fire and Fury Corps and the Forest, Ecology and Environment Department of Union territory administration

under the Global Snow Leopard and Ecosystem Protection (GSLEP) programme, a defence spokesman said.

The agreement was signed in the presence of Lt General Hitesh Bhalla, General Officer Commanding (GOC), Fire and Fury Corps, and Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra.

Describing the initiative as a "historic step towards wildlife conservation", the spokesperson said the partnership seeks to promote sustainable development and environmental protection in Ladakh's high-altitude ecosystems and reaffirms the shared commitment to preserving its rich biodiversity and



fragile ecology for future generations. The collaboration will focus on conserving flagship

species such as the snow leopard, Himalayan wolf, 'bharal' (blue sheep), ibex, marmot and

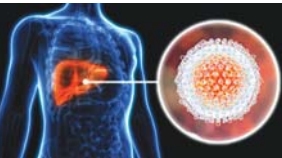
black-necked crane, along with protection of their natural habitats. Officials said the Army has consistently worked towards balancing the twin responsibilities of safeguarding the nation's borders and protecting the region's flora and fauna.

As part of the initiative, a joint Snow Leopard Conservation Cell will be established to monitor conservation efforts and further the objectives of species protection in the ecologically sensitive region, they said, adding that the partnership would create a framework for adopting eco-friendly practices and strengthening coordinated conservation measures in Ladakh.

Haryana to strengthen viral hepatitis surveillance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Haryana has decided to comprehensively strengthen surveillance, reporting and treatment monitoring of viral hepatitis under the National Viral Hepatitis Control Programme.



The initiative will focus on enforceable compliance, real-time data integration and measurable outcomes to eliminate gaps in detection and treatment. Additional chief secretary, Health Department, Sumita Misra on Tuesday.

It has been observed that reporting remains fragmented and largely confined to Government institutions, with inadequate participation from private hospitals, nursing homes and diagnostic laboratories, an official statement said.

Misra has underlined that since Hepatitis B and C are notified diseases, surveillance cannot remain partial or advisory in nature; it must be comprehensive, enforceable and outcome-oriented.



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**Delhi court rejects bail
plea of alleged kingpin
in bank fraud case**



A Delhi court has dismissed the bail plea of an alleged kingpin in an over ₹8.94 crore bank fraud case, saying the offence was grave and committed in a systematic manner through layered transactions.

Additional Sessions Judge Shunali Gupta rejected the bail application of accused Nitin Birmal Dongre in an FIR registered by the Economic Offences Wing (South) under Sections 318(4) (cheating of valuable security), 319(2)(cheating by personation), 316(4) (criminal breach of trust), 336(3)(forgery), 338 (forgery of valuable security), 340(2)(fraudulent use of forged documents), and 61(2) (criminal conspiracy) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

“Considering the seriousness and gravity of the offence, the systematic manner in which huge amount of ₹8.94 crores has been withdrawn from the bank account of the complainant by hatching a criminal conspiracy wherein the applicant was a kingpin and two other persons stated to be involved in the same are yet to be arrested, at this stage, I do not find any ground for grant of bail to the applicant,” the court said in its order dated February 28.

On January 10, 2008, a current account in the name of Larsen & Toubro and Shanghai Urban Construction Operation was opened at Axis Bank’s Lajpat Nagar branch in Delhi. On June 7, 2024, forged documents were allegedly used to change the phone number linked to the account.

**Delhi court denies anticipatory bail to
IPS officer in illegal raid, extortion case**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has dismissed the anticipatory bail plea of a senior AGMUT cadre IPS officer who is accused of conducting unauthorised raids in the national capital, illegally detaining multiple persons and demanding money from a foreign national.

The offences committed by the applicant “undermine the integrity of the justice system, erode public trust and tarnish the image of police as a whole”, Special Judge (NDPS) Manu Goel



Suspended IPS officer Shankar Chaudhary

Kharb said in an order while refusing bail to Shankar Chaudhary. The matter is related to alleged police operations conducted between November 21 and 29, 2023,



A conspiracy narrative, meticulously constructed by the Union Government and the Delhi Police regarding the “shirtless” protest at the India AI Impact Summit 2026, has suffered a significant blow. The legal developments of the past three days have turned into a setback for the authorities.

The alleged mastermind, Indian Youth Congress National President Uday Bhanu Chib, has walked out of custody following a grant of bail. Several other accused persons have also secured their release.

By losing custody of Chib, the police have effectively lost their best chance to “break” the case. In high-profile conspiracy matters, a failure to secure a full remand is often interpreted as a sign of insufficient evidence.

It has been a bumpy road for the prosecution in the ten days since the incident. The turning point arrived on February 28 when a Duty Magistrate at the Patiala House Court refused to extend police remand, granting Chib bail during a midnight hearing.

Stung by the ruling, the Delhi Police rushed to the Sessions Court and initially succeeded in staying the release. However, Chib’s legal team moved the Delhi High Court, which on March 2 overturned the stay, paving the way for his release. With the trial court also

granting bail to nine additional accused, the prosecution has been dealt a double blow. Investigators termed the incident of protest as a “deep-rooted conspiracy” to disrupt the international event. However, the developments since February 28 have shaken the Delhi Police’s confidence, as the court’s skepticism suggests the ‘conspiracy’ narrative may be lacking sufficient evidentiary support.

These developments are particularly significant as they have unfolded before investigators could fully utilise the 14-day window for custodial interrogation.

What was baffling was that the Sessions Court had stayed the bail order—notably doing so in an ex parte hearing without granting the accused an opportunity to respond. The High Court’s decision to overturn that stay was primarily based on a lack of judicial reasoning and the failure to justify an ex parte intervention in a matter involving personal liberty.

This judicial pushback has already compromised the momentum of the ongoing investigation. The grant of bail to the Youth Congress President by the Magistrate, barely a week after the incident, undoubtedly shocked the central Government and shook the confidence of the investigators. The Sessions Court’s favourable order turned out to be short-lived for the prosecution, which now finds itself in a catch-22 position regarding whether to move to a superior court.

To understand the legal ramifications of the case, it is necessary to capture the sequence of events on which the theory of a deep-rooted conspiracy was placed

before the court to take the demonstrators and others into custody. The “shirtless” protest at the India AI Impact Summit 2026 took place on February 20, 2026. The demonstration occurred around noon inside Exhibition Hall No. 5 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi. It has since triggered a significant political and legal standoff.

Members of the Indian Youth Congress were later arrested. Protesters entered the high-security venue by registering online for the summit. Once inside, they removed their outer layers (jackets and sweaters) to reveal T-shirts with slogans such as “PM is compromised” and messages regarding the “India-US Trade Deal.” The Youth Congress activists were protesting against the Government’s policies and specific trade agreements with the United States, choosing the international summit as a platform to draw global attention.

Multiple arrests were made by the Delhi Police in the days following the event. The incident led to a dramatic inter-state police standoff on February 26, 2026, when Delhi Police arrested more activists in Himachal Pradesh, leading to a jurisdictional dispute with the Himachal Pradesh Police and a kidnapping case registered against Delhi Police by local authorities.

The arrests in Himachal Pradesh led to a high-profile standoff between the Delhi and Himachal Pradesh police forces over procedural lapses, as the local Shimla police were reportedly not informed of the raid. As of late February 2026, a total of 14 people have been

arrested in connection with the protest. The arrests were made in phases from different states as the Delhi Police expanded their investigation into what they termed a “deep-rooted conspiracy” to disrupt the international event.

Chib, the alleged mastermind, was arrested after 20 hours of questioning on February 24. Police allege he orchestrated the logistics and funding for the demonstration. Police allege these individuals were responsible for “direct involvement” and the digital documentation (filming and photography) used to circulate the protest on social media.

The case has been transferred to the Delhi Police Crime Branch. Most of the accused are currently in police custody under charges including: Criminal Conspiracy, Promoting Enmity between groups, Assault or Obstruction of a public servant, and Rioting.

Investigators are not considering the incident as a spontaneous political demonstration. They argue that the protest was a calculated effort to undermine India’s national security and global reputation. By staging the demonstration in front of global tech leaders and foreign dignitaries at Bharat Mandapam, the police claim the intent was to “tarnish the Republic’s diplomatic image” and portray India as unstable to foreign stakeholders.

In court, investigators compared the demonstration to “GenZ-led protests in Nepal” from the previous year. They allege the protesters used a specific “toolkit” or model of agitation designed to create high visual impact for social media while bypassing traditional

security measures. Police are investigating the “financial trails” to see who funded the printing of specialised T-shirts and the travel of activists from multiple states (Bihar, UP, Telangana, and MP). Investigators are scanning deleted social media posts and encrypted messages to identify “handlers” who may have directed the arrested individuals.

Despite these claims of a “deep conspiracy,” Chib was granted bail as the Magistrate noted the police had not provided sufficient grounds to extend his custody further, effectively dismantling the narrative of a coordinated, “Nepal-style” sabotage. These findings and observations will have a bearing on the case, primarily because the remarks directly challenged the “conspiracy” narrative investigators had built.

The police had sought a 7-day extension of Chib’s custody, arguing they needed more time to “confront” him with other accused and trace financial trails. The Duty Magistrate dismissed this plea, stating that the Crime Branch had failed to explain the reasons for needing more time. Effectively, there was a signal that the four days of interrogation already completed should have been sufficient to gather primary evidence.

A central part of the police’s argument was that the protest compromised national sovereignty and security. In a notable observation, the Magistrate stated: “Merely saying the sovereignty was compromised does not justify prolonged custody.” This suggests the court found the police’s high-level charges (such as those hinting at sedition or a threat to the Republic)

were not backed by enough concrete evidence to deny an individual their liberty.

The police faced criticism for the timing of the hearing. They produced Chib before the magistrate at 1:30 am on a Saturday morning, just as his previous remand was ending. The defence called this a “panic” move, and the decision to grant bail despite the odd hour suggests it saw no emergency or “sensitive” reason to keep him in jail.

Earlier last week, the court had already dealt the police a blow by forcing them to provide a copy of the FIR to Chib. The police had claimed the FIR was “sensitive in nature” and could not be shared; the court called this claim “untenable” and said denying the document violated constitutional safeguards.

The grant of bail to the alleged mastermind of the crime was unexpected. However, the Magistrate’s order and the outcome of bail matter in the High Court have given much-needed ammunition to the Congress Party and its youth wing, which has been justifying the mode of protest.

The order has also served as a lesson to the prosecution to undertake course correction and reconsider the manner in which they sought the extension of the Youth Congress Chief during the midnight hearing. Such a strategy by the investigators does not inspire confidence in the mode of probe. Further, the justification for the stay of the bail order would have been strengthened if the accused had been heard, which is now clear from the High Court decision.

Writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs



**Need to curb unwanted appeals
as default reaction: Law ministry**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A tendency among Central Ministries and Departments to file appeals against court orders as a “default reaction” rather than as a considered policy decision was flagged as a “key challenge” to curb litigation in which the Government is a party. At a recent conference on effective and efficient management of Government litigation, over two dozen Union Secretaries and top law officers recommended a clear appeal-filtering criteria in service and other matters, nomination of a designated officer in each department for coordinated handling of litigation, and mechanisms for time-bound implementation of court judgments so that repetitive and contempt litigation is minimised.

The conference, organised here on Saturday by the Union Law Ministry, noted key



challenges such as repetitive service litigation due to non-uniform implementation of legal position, lack of due consultation before filing counter affidavits, divergent positions taken by different ministries, lack of coordination between departments and panel counsels, and a tendency to file appeals as a default reaction rather than as a considered policy decision.

According to officials and

utilisation of alternate dispute resolution and pre-litigation mediation were also flagged as areas of concern.

A central emphasis of the deliberations was on reducing avoidable litigation and delays in litigation filing through robust filtering, better coordination and early dispute resolution.

The Law Ministry had in February last year told Rajya Sabha that the Central Government is a party in nearly seven lakh cases pending across courts, with the finance ministry alone being one of the litigants in nearly two lakh cases.

Citing data available on the Legal Information Management & Briefing System (LIMBS), Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said, “There are about seven lakh cases pending where the Government of India is a party. Out of these, in about 1.9 lakh cases, the Ministry of Finance is mentioned as a party.”

**Permit five people named by court for symbolic
prayers atop Tirupparankundram hill: HC to TN Govt**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Madurai

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has suggested to the administration to permit five persons named by the court to offer symbolic prayers for 15 minutes near the stone pillar atop the Tirupparankundram hill.

Hearing a contempt petition filed for non-compliance of an earlier direction on lighting Karthigai Deepam atop the Deepathoon, the court said the symbolic prayers (not lighting the lamp) could be allowed if the Government wanted to show respect to the earlier orders of the court.

Also, the Bench comprising Justice GR Swaminathan



Tirupparankundram temple

remarked that state Minerals and Mines Minister S Regupathy had “given a mischievous political spin” to the Tirupparankundram issue when he stated that the Government would not

permit the lighting of the Karthigai Deepam at the Deepathoon (stone pillar). Madurai collector KJ Praveen Kumar had filed an additional affidavit stating that he promulgated the pro-

hibition orders on December 1, 2025, in order to prevent law and order situation and not to hinder temple authorities from enforcing the high court’s orders to light the lamp at the stone pillar.

Responding, Justice Swaminathan said on March 2, “I suggest that respect to the order passed by this court can be shown by permitting a group of five persons to be named by this court to go to the lower peak of the hillock where the Deepathoon lies so that the symbolic prayers can be offered.”

“I further indicate that this entire exercise can be confined to 15 minutes. This is only a suggestion and not a direction,” he added.

**Case lodged against hospital after part of
infant’s finger inadvertently amputated**

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ghaziabad

A case of alleged medical negligence has been registered against the management of Sarvodaya Hospital (a private hospital) in the Kavinagar area of Uttar Pradesh’s Ghaziabad district and a nurse after part of a nine-month-old girl’s little finger was inadvertently amputated, police said on Monday.

The nurse was removing a cannula from the left hand of the infant, identified as Shree Tyagi, the police said.

According to the complaint filed by her father Ankush Tyagi, the child was admitted to the facility on February 24 for treatment. On February 27, while the family was completing the discharge



formalities, a nurse arrived to remove the cannula (a tube inserted into the body to deliver or withdraw fluids, medication or blood) from the infant’s hand, during which the alleged incident took place.

The complainant alleged that the nurse used a pair of scissors to cut through the adhesive surgical tape securing the medical device. In the

process, she inadvertently partially amputated the child’s finger.

The FIR was formally registered on February 28 on the complaint lodged by Ankush Tyagi.

Assistant Commissioner of Police (Kavi Nagar) Suryabali Maurya said that an investigation is currently underway. “A charge sheet will be submitted in court after a thorough probe. Additionally, a copy of the findings will be forwarded to the Indian Medical Council for further administrative oversight,” ACP Maurya said.

No arrests have been made in the case, Maurya said, and added that a case has been registered under Section 125 (B) (act endangering life or personal safety of others) of the BNS.



Editor's
TAKE

West Asia tensions rattle rupee and markets

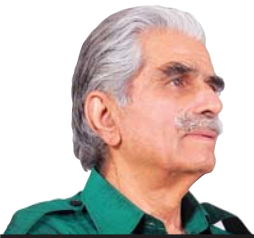
West Asia conflict has jolted global markets, pushing up oil prices and pressuring the rupee. The RBI has cautiously moved to steady the currency

The West Asian has started taking toll on the geo-economics. When the US attacked Iran, it was beginning of a war that had all the makings of a regional war. And it did become a regional war quickly as Iran retaliated and attacked the US bases across the Gulf. The widening scope of the war has bruised the business sentiments across the world markets. Back home in India, as elsewhere, the oil prices are going up and rupee continues to depreciate. Equities and bonds are also under strain. Meanwhile, the Reserve Bank of India is making efforts to hold the currency from downside. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has intervened and sold dollars through state-run banks after the rupee came under pressure. The currency fell nearly 0.4 per cent to around 91.37 per dollar, after touching an intraday low of 91.4250. India is particularly vulnerable to any disruption in the Gulf as it imports more than 80 per cent of its crude oil requirements pushes up its current account deficit. A sharply depreciating rupee would compound the problem by making oil imports even costlier in domestic currency terms. But India's problems are not confined to oil import bill alone. Its financial markets are also showing negative sentiment which can hurt India's growth story. India's benchmark equity indices - the BSE Sensex and the Nifty 50 - declined more than one per cent. Meanwhile, the yield on the 10-year benchmark government bond rose by over 3 basis points to around 6.70 per cent. Rising yields suggest investor concern over inflationary risks and the possibility of higher borrowing costs ahead.

If the West Asian crisis is not resolved soon, the macroeconomic implications of sustained oil price increases would be catastrophic. Oil prices feed inflation – raising transportation costs, manufacturing expenses, and food prices. Besides, there is a fiscal dimension as well. Higher fuel prices can force the government into difficult trade-offs. Passing the full burden on to consumers risks fuelling inflation and dampening consumption. Absorbing part of the shock through excise duty reductions, on the other hand, strains public finances at a time when infrastructure spending and welfare commitments already demand substantial resources. Indeed, this can be managed in a short run as India is not without buffers. Foreign exchange reserves remain sizable, providing the RBI with elbow room. The country has diversified its crude sourcing in recent years. Robust services exports and steady remittance inflows continue to support the balance of payments. But as long as India remains heavily dependent on imported fossil fuels, geopolitical shocks in energy-producing regions will continue to ripple through its economy. For now, the RBI's steady and calibrated intervention may save the day. But if tensions escalate further, balancing currency stability, inflation control, fiscal prudence, and growth in an increasingly volatile global environment would be a challenge.

Nepal elections: A Litmus test for old parties

With traditional parties bruised, new political forces surging, and security tightened to unprecedented levels, this vote is more than a routine democratic exercise – it is a reckoning with corruption, misgovernance and the unfulfilled promises



ASHOK K
MEHTA

Very few in Nepal initially believed an election on 5 March after the Gen Z protests was feasible; that it would even happen, given the chaotic and traumatic two-day protests last year which culminated in 77 protestors becoming martyrs and arson and mayhem leading to jailbreak, loss of weapons by police and damage to public property estimated at around USD5bn. A country with a GDP of USD 45bn, FE reserves of USD 10 bn and one third of its population of 30mn abroad, could ill afford such enormous loss. Until just two weeks before elections, doubters said Parliament will be restored; election postponed; GenZ revolt will repeat even as PM Sushila Karki cautioned against not factoring GenZ concerns during the elections. On 7 January I had said on this page that elections would be held on 5 March. The Nepal Army has been Karki's biggest supporter and pillar of confidence. This may be the first time Army will be in close proximity of voter booths. Security of ballot boxes has become a big concern.

The Proportional Representation system which does not allow a single party majority was introduced in 2015 constitution and parliamentary seats were enhanced from 205 to 275 with 165 First Past the Post (FPTP) and 110 through Proportional Representation (PR). A voter has to cast two votes: one for the chosen candidate and the other for his favoured party. This time, 120 parties are contesting of which 22 are new with 68 parties contesting FPTP seats. 3400 candidates of which 1000 are below 40 years of age are running for 275-member Parliament. 800,000 are new voters. The three traditional parties are five times PM SB Deuba-led Nepali Congress, four times PM KP Oli's CPN UML and four times PM Prachanda-led CPN (Maoists). GenZ Andolan ousted the UML and NC coalition with the people's wrath targeting Oli and Deuba, both their parties being badly tarnished. Most parties have praised GenZ revolution endorsing their reform agenda except Oli who was forced to quit and taken into Army's safe custody. "No to Oli" graffiti is still visible in most places across Nepal. To remove the image of discredited leaders, NC's youthful Gagan Thapa executed a bloodless coup replacing Deuba as party president and becoming the party's PM face. This has created an internal rift in NC between the old guard and the young Turks. UML's Ishwor Pokhrel tried to dislodge Oli but failed.

Last month, Rashtriya Swatantra Party (Bell symbol) secured a reprieve with its jailed leader Ravi Lamichhane released on bail and permitted to contest elections. A former Home



THE OUTCOME OF GENZ REVOLUTION COULD RESULT IN A SHOCK AND AWE OUTCOME FOR TRADITIONAL PARTIES

The writer, a retired Major General, served as Commander, IPKF (South), Sri Lanka, and was a founder member of the Defence Planning Staff, now the Integrated Defence Staff

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Minister in the last Parliament he had several cases of misconduct including fraud. A shot in the arm came for RSP from the popular Kathmandu mayor, Balen Shah joining the party as its PM candidate. The popularity of leaders in Nepal is measured by the word 'craze' with the Balen wave and craze storming most parts of Nepal. Among the new parties is Ujjiyalo Nepal, led by former technocrat Kulman Ghising credited with ending Nepal's perennial power outages. The Rashtriya Prajatantra Party which backs restoration of monarchy and Hindu Rashtira has "too many chiefs, few Indians". There is a fresh surge

for returning former King Gyanendra to Narayanhiti Palace. Terai parties have split Madhesi vote once bagged by the Sadbhavana Party. In 2008 elections, the slogan 'ek Madhes ek Pradesh' never fructified and even the diminished Madhes province is dominated by hill-region political parties.

In the last 2022 elections NC emerged single largest party with 89 seats, UML 78 seats, Maoist 32 seats, RSP 21 and RPP 14 seats. An estimate of the 5 March vote shows a fractured verdict with RSP emerging as single largest with 100 to 110, NC 55 to 60, UML 50 to 55, NCP (the rechristened Maoists) 10 to 15, RPP 15-20. It is not clear how and when will GenZ reform agenda get incorporated in the 10-point agreement with Karki as it involves constitutional amendments. In Bangladesh the Feb 12 elections were accompanied by a simultaneous referendum on constitutional reform contained in the July National Charter. But when the winning BNP MPs took oath, they did not swear allegiance to the July National Charter. In Nepal, despite Karki's constant reminders to political parties about the GenZ "concerns" little is known how they will be accommodated.

Most political parties except UML have generally backed their proposals.

2 March was the last day for campaigning - and Holi. Our village, an NC stronghold near Pokhara, was visited by NC and RSP candidates contesting the parliamentary seat. Bells began ringing when RSP's Uttam Paudyal greeted us. That's the mood here. Punish old parties and canvas for change. While NC election posters bear pictures of Gagan Thapa and BP Koirala,

RSP is championing for Ravi Lamichhane and Balen Shah. NC's election slogan is: "Congress Badlaao, Desh Badlaao" and "abki baar sau paar". RSP's message is simple: "abki bar

Balen Sarkar". The fervour for change is palpable. RSP campaign teams are young and spirited for a party that made its debut in 2022. It has spread hope for a corruption-free Nepal though its detractors are saying that Lamichhane is the fountain of fraud.

No violent incidents have occurred though clashes have taken place for other reasons. Like the 2008 elections that followed the decade-long Maoist civil war where the results were a complete surprise, conferring a landslide victory for the Maoists when traditional parties were expected frontrunners. Similarly, the outcome of GenZ revolution could result in a shock and awe outcome for traditional parties. GenZ was so vastly disparate it could not form a party. In Bangladesh the protesting students won just eight to nine seats. In Nepal people want to punish the UML-NC coalition government led by Oli. That is precisely what the reading of the mood is.

The 5 March election is a litmus test for traditional parties and their record of corruption and misgovernance. 'Parivartan' is the buzzword here. RSP's Balen Shah, a Madhesi, is likely to become the first PM of Nepal from Madhes.

PIC TALK



Women apply 'gula' during celebrations of 'Basant Utsav', on the occasion of 'Dol Purnima', in Nadia, West Bengal

PHOTO: PTI



RAJYOGI
BRAHMAKUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Most of us dread a conflict situation in our life, because it makes us uncomfortable and stressful. As a result, we learn to avoid, suppress or withdraw from conflict or even act as though it doesn't exist.

The conflict in human life begins from the time the infant is yet in its mother's womb. Whether it would be a male or a female baby, a prodigy or a dunce, a veritable beauty or ugliness personified? —these are some of the questions that raise ripples in the minds of the parents and later, determine their attitudes towards the newly-born, especially if it is a female child. These attitudes, in turn, leave an imprint or a scar on their psyche which, in its own turn, influences their behaviour that becomes the cause of conflicts in the society. In some societies, these are minor questions

whereas in others, in which the female is still looked upon as an inferior being as compared to a male, these and related questions are considered as big ones. The example of the gender-difference of the baby is now at the periphery of the wheel of problems. At the centre of the circle now is the troika of social, economic and political conflicts. These conflicts have now taken a highly aggravated pitch. And, of these three, the political conflicts have, of late, taken a very virulent form.

What is drawing maximum attention in India are the events related to extremism and violent and subversive acts. Many of these conflicts have arisen from differences in political ideologies. Some minority groups complain that there is social and political discrimination towards them and that the government is intolerant to the ideological minorities and that there is police intimidation and harassment and internment without trial. The government, on the other hand, says that these groups indulge in subversive and anti-constitutional activities and in espionage and political hostage taking extremist acts and that they (the government) have, therefore, to act with an iron hand.

There are no constructive and meaningful dialogues and, instead, there is violent confrontation. There is social apathy and a high degree of hatred on both sides. The result is that, in such a pluralistic society, there has developed violent disintegration. There are no efforts on either side to win

the other by love, friendship and spirit of reconciliation. The result is that tensions are rising rapidly high and life is becoming increasingly insecure.

A growing body of research has shown spirituality as a great antidote for all kinds of conflicts. Spirituality is like the medicine which heals the root of the disease and not just the symptoms. It is the only means that gives us complete solutions to conflicts. From a spiritual perspective, the simplest and the most powerful value needed for conflict resolution is 'respect'. This is because most of the people don't wish to negotiate when they are in possession of material power.

Therefore, there's an urgent need for those to realise and respect their inner powers. Similarly, faith is also a very important element in conflict resolution, it is the key to mutual understanding. For global conflicts the solution lies with the leadership. The leaders can bring about the much-needed change and make it trickle down the societies. Leaders of today must remember that any kind of change can be termed 'real' only when it affects the grassroots. It is thus very important to recognize that the world shall change, when I change. Hence, people should not wait to be told that they need to change, instead they should realize it themselves.

The writer is a spiritual Guru and a popular columnist

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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INDIA'S BREAST CANCER CASES SURGE NEARLY FIVE-FOLD SINCE 1990

India's breast cancer burden has risen sharply over the past three decades, with new cases increasing nearly five-fold since 1990, reflecting a troubling global trend, according to a new analysis published in The Lancet Oncology. Using 2023 data from cancer registries, government records and family interviews, researchers found a steep rise in both diagnoses and deaths.

India recorded nearly 2.03 lakh new breast cancer cases in 2023 – a 477.8% increase from 1990. Deaths climbed to 1.02 lakh, marking a 352.3% rise.

The age-standardised incidence rate stood at 29.4 per one lakh women, up 126.9% over three decades, while the death rate reached 15.5 per one lakh – a 74% increase.

Globally, breast cancer cases are projected to grow from 23 lakh in

2023 to over 35 lakh by 2050, with annual deaths expected to nearly double to 14 lakh. The World Health Organisation notes breast cancer was the most commonly diagnosed cancer among women in 157 of 185 countries in 2022. Experts attribute the rise to population ageing, lifestyle changes, delayed childbirth, obesity, and limited access to early screening in many regions.

Late diagnosis remains a major challenge in India. While high-income countries have stabilised incidence and reduced mortality through screening and improved treatment, low- and middle-income nations like India continue to see rapid increases in both cases and deaths, underscoring the urgent need for stronger public health interventions.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Safety as the basis of sustainable progress

National Safety Day, observed every year on March 4 in India, is a reminder that genuine progress is measured not only by economic growth but by the safety with which it is achieved. When safety is prioritised, lives are protected, assets preserved, and productivity strengthened. A secure environment builds confidence among workers and communities, creating the stability necessary for long-term success. Sustainable development can flourish only when safety is treated as a core value rather than an afterthought. The 2026 theme, "Engage, Educate & Empower People to Enhance Safety," reinforces this commitment. It highlights the importance of active participation, continuous learning, and individual responsibility. When employees are encouraged to identify hazards, understand the purpose behind safety protocols, and feel empowered to act promptly, accidents and avoidable losses decline significantly. Safety awareness must also extend beyond industrial settings to roads, homes, schools, and public spaces. Embedding responsible behaviour into daily life strengthens communities and promotes resilience. By making accident prevention a consistent practice, we lay the groundwork for secure, inclusive, and meaningful progress for future generations.

KRISHNA KUMAR VEPAKOMMA | HYDERABAD

Balance diplomacy and domestic stability

The killing of Ayatollah Khamenei has sparked protests among Shia communities across parts of West Asia, South Asia and Europe. Demonstrators have denounced the alleged involvement of the United States and Israel, voicing anger and demanding justice. These reactions underscore deep religious solidarity intertwined with fraught geopolitical tensions, heightening fears of retaliatory violence and wider regional instability. Any escalation in the Gulf could threaten shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, disrupting global oil supplies and sharply raising prices – a serious concern for import-dependent economies such as India. New Delhi has so far adopted a cautious and restrained position, urging dialogue while refraining from direct condemnation. This calibrated response reflects India's need to preserve strategic ties with both Iran and its Western partners. However, prolonged unrest carries risks at home. In regions like Kashmir, where emotional and religious affinity with Iran exists, tensions could test internal security and social cohesion. India can play a constructive role by advocating restraint at global forums, engaging community leaders domestically, and ensuring transparent communication – reaffirming its commitment to peace and sovereignty.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Gen Z wishes to become job creators, not seekers

For a country adding millions to its workforce each year, this generational pivot is not merely cultural; it is structural. The true opportunity before India lies in harnessing this mindset shift – transforming a generation of job seekers into confident job creators capable of reshaping the nation’s economic future



DINESH SOOD

India is observing a silent but profound career revolution. For decades, the pathway to success was linear and predictable: complete education, secure a stable job, and climb the corporate ladder. That model is now being questioned, if not dismantled, by Generation Z. Across Indian campuses, young people are increasingly choosing freelancing, side hustles, portfolio careers, and entrepreneurial experiments over traditional 9 am to 5 pm employment.

At first glance, this seems to be a quest for freedom, flexibility, and better mental health. Still beneath this shift lies a more consequential transformation: Gen Z is moving away from employment dependency toward economic self-reliance. The real opportunity and challenge for India is to ensure this generation evolves not just into job seekers navigating an uncertain labour market, but into job creators forming the country's economic future.

From career stability to career sovereignty

Gen Z's rejection of rigid career timelines is not driven solely by rebellion; economic realities and technological possibilities inform it. According to Upwork, more than 52 per cent of Gen Z professionals globally have engaged in freelance work, and nearly 39 per cent identify as "portfolio careerists," managing multiple income streams instead of relying on a single employer. Fiverr global research reinforces this shift, showing that nearly 70 per cent of Gen Z consider freelancing a viable long-term career option, 64 per cent value location independence, 62 per cent value meaningful work, and 61 per cent want control over career paths.

This generation values autonomy, purpose, and flexibility as much as income security. A 21-year-old student in a small town like Moga, Punjab, freelancing as a social media strategist, captures this mindset: he would rather earn less at first but retain control over his time and choices. Such thinking shows a broader shift from career stability to career sovereignty.

However, this transition also reflects



THIS GENERATION VALUES AUTONOMY, PURPOSE, AND FLEXIBILITY AS MUCH AS INCOME SECURITY

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necessity. India adds nearly 12 million young people to its workforce each year, yet regulated job creation has not kept pace. The Periodic Labour Force Survey consistently shows elevated unemployment rates among youth compared to older age groups. This mismatch means conventional employment alone cannot absorb India's demographic surge. In this context, entrepreneurship and self-employment are no longer lifestyle choices; they are financial necessities.

The first step toward entrepreneurship

Freelancing and gig work are often viewed as alternatives to formal employment, but they can serve as stepping stones toward entrepreneurship. When young people freelance, they acquire critical business skills, including client acquisition, negotiation, financial management, marketing, and service delivery. These are the capabilities required to build and scale enterprises.

India's startup ecosystem provides powerful examples of what happens

when young people are empowered to create rather than seek employment. Ritesh Agarwal founded OYO Rooms at 19, transforming a small idea into one of the world's largest hospitality platforms. Today, OYO supports thousands of hotel partners and employs tens of thousands directly and indirectly. Similarly, Aadit Palicha, co-founder of quick-commerce platform Zepto, built a company in his early twenties that has created thousands of jobs across technology, logistics, and operations. Success stories are not isolated. According to Startup India, the country now has over 100,000 registered startups that have collectively generated more than 1 million direct jobs. Each startup embodies more than innovation; it embodies employment multiplication-one entrepreneur creating opportunities for many others.

Skills, not degrees, are the new economic currency

One of Gen Z's defining characteristics lies

in its emphasis on skills over credentials. Nearly 40 per cent of Gen Z respondents in global surveys believe formal degrees alone are no longer sufficient for success. Instead, digital and entrepreneurial skills such as coding, digital marketing, artificial intelligence, financial literacy, and communication are becoming the new drivers of economic mobility.

Technology has lowered barriers to entry. Today, a young person in a small town with internet access can serve clients globally, launch digital products, or build an online business. Platforms such as Shopify, YouTube, and Upwork have democratised entrepreneurship in new ways.

Yet India's education system remains oriented toward producing job seekers rather than job creators. Universities still measure success through placement statistics rather than startup creation. Students are trained to conduct clear interviews, not to identify market gaps, build solutions, or manage enterprises.

The institutional and policy imperative

If India is to transform its demographic dividend into an economic dividend, fundamental changes are essential. Colleges must integrate entrepreneurship, financial literacy, and digital skills into mainstream curricula. Startup incubators, innovation labs, and flexible academic pathways must become the norm, not the exception. Initiatives such as Startup India, Skill India, and Digital India have established a solid foundation. But their true impact will depend on accessibility and implementation beyond major metropolitan centres. India's next generation of job creators will not emerge only from Bengaluru and Delhi, but also from smaller cities and towns where talent has long remained underutilised.

Equally important is a shift in social attitudes. Risk-taking must be encouraged, not discouraged. Failure must be seen as a learning process, not a permanent stigma. Families, educators, and policy-makers have to nurture a culture that appreciates innovation and self-reliance.

An awakening moment for the future

Gen Z is not rejecting work; it is rejecting dependency. This generation is redefining careers as dynamic, self-directed journeys rather than fixed ladders. It is not seeking just employment, but agency.

India stands at a historic inflexion point. By 2030, Gen Z will form a dominant share of the workforce. If equipped only with degrees and job-seeking skills, they may face frustration and underemployment. But with entrepreneurial skills, digital capabilities, and institutional support, they can become engines of economic growth.

The responsibility is shared. Schools must nurture creative thinking and problem-solving. Universities must encourage enterprise creation alongside placements. Decision-makers must expand access to skills and startup ecosystems. Young people themselves must embrace persistent learning, adaptability, and measured risk-taking.

This is the wake-up call. Gen Z does not need to be prepared just for employment. It needs to be empowered for the enterprise. When young people choose to become job creators rather than job seekers, they do more than transform their personal destinies; they reshape the nation's economic destiny.

A marriage veto violates constitutional rights



ARVIND P BHANU MAYUKH ROY

The recently proposed amendment to the Gujarat Registration of Marriages Act, 2006 has sparked debate over adult personal liberty, conflicting with existing laws and society's/state commitment to women's empowerment. Announced in early 2026, the proposed law seeks to "protect family values," curb alleged "love jihad" activities, and prevent coercion and fraudulent identities. While the state may extend legal protections to adults entering marriage, it must safeguard their constitutional freedom and liberty. The position pre and post proposed amendment is (1) Provisions (pre-amendment) - Gujarat Registration of Marriages Act, 2006 - No requirement of parental consent; registration is for civil procedure ensuring legal recognition of marriage. (2) Provision (post-amendment, 2026) - Amendment 2026 - For marriages/inter-caste or inter-faith marriages, couples must submit a notarised parental consent form alongside the marriage certificate. The parent/s has to submit their ID like Aadhar card along with approval for issuing the marriage registration certificate. The prosed law makes marriage registration mandatory. (3) Key Features - the amendment applies to marriages crossing caste or religious boundaries; same-caste/faith unions remain unaffected. Enforcement is delegated to registrar of marriages, who may request additional verification of consent. The amendment is justified by the state as a measure to "prevent forced conversion and preserve social harmony". But what will happen to the status of marriage when parents does not give approval. The parents may use their veto where they may not be comfortable due to social, religious and cultural etc obstructions. This veto introduces a statutory barrier that directly interferes with adult individual's autonomy over marital choices.

Sections 4 to 8 of the Special Marriage Act, 1954, provide a structured civil framework for marriage, independent of religious customs. Conditions (Section 4): Establishes mandatory criteria: monogamy, sound mental health, minimum age (21 for males, 18 for females), and avoiding prohibited relationships. Notice and Publication (Sections 5-6): Parties must file a notice in a district where one has resided for 30 days. This notice is publicly displayed to ensure transparency. Objections and Inquiry (Sections 7-8): A 30-day window allows for public objections based on



Section 4 criteria. The Marriage Officer must investigate objections within 30 days; if upheld, parties can appeal to a district court. This process ensures that civil marriages are transparent, consensual, and legally vetted before solemnization. The proposed law does not go with hand in hand with this central legislation.

Along with these provisions the Supreme Court has consistently interpreted Article 21 of the constitution as encompassing the right to marry a partner of one's own choosing. In Laxmibai Chandaragi B vs. State of Karnataka (2021), the court held that the freedom to marry without parental interference is a facet of personal liberty and privacy. The judgement emphasized that any state-imposed condition that curtails this liberty must be narrowly tailored and justified by a compelling public interest. Shafi Jahan vs K.M. Ashokan (2018) reinforced that discrimination on the basis of caste or religion in matrimonial matters violates the equality clause. The court observed that the state cannot impose "socially regressive" restrictions that perpetuate historical hierarchies. The Court intervened by setting aside the High Court's ruling, stating that the marriage was valid as Hadiya was a consenting adult, and that parental approval is not a legal requirement. Reliance was made in article 21 of the Constitution. In Lata Singh vs State of Uttar Pradesh (2006), the court protected an inter-caste couple from familial coercion directing law enforcement agencies to safeguard their right to marry and to prevent intimidation. The judgement highlighted the parental consent requirements can become instruments of violence, particularly against women. Collectively, these decisions articulate a clear constitutional trajectory: adult individuals possess an entrenched right to marry and not to marry without parental approval, and any legislative intrusion must survive strict scrutiny.

Why the Gujarat Amendment falters?

The state argues that the amendment prevents "love-jihad" and protects cultural integrity. However, the Supreme Court has repeatedly rejected communal anxieties as a basis for restricting fundamental rights. In Shayara Bano vs. Union of India (2017), the court held that the moral panic cannot outweigh individual liberty.

No empirical data have been presented to demonstrate that parental consent reduces forced conversions; rather, the provision appears to codify communal suspicion. Empirical studies on inter-community marriages reveal that women bear the brunt of familial opposition and violence. By legally obligating parental consent, the amendment amplifies the leverage of male family members, contravening the protective rationale articulated in Lata Singh case (2006). Judicial precedent demands that any restriction on personal liberty be the least intrusive means available.

The Gujarat amendment imposes a blanket consent requirement, irrespective of whether coercion is present. A more narrowly tailored approach such as a judicial review mechanism for alleged duress would satisfy the state's interest without infringing on constitutional rights.

Plus we must also think of the logical problems it creates for two distinct set of people, first are those who somehow after coming of this amendment have gotten married now are liable to be penalised plus if the family now uses their so-called "veto power", as above stated, what happens do we break the family unit by declaring such marriage void ab initio? Secondly, if someone has married under the Special Marriages Act, 1954 in the past few years and that too without their parent's consent then can now the parents of such couple voice their dissent to such marriage and what will be the outcome of such dissent on the marriage? The newly proposed amendment leaves with far too many questions and uncertainties and with far few answers. This lack of sheer lack of clarity and predictability is never good for any legal system as it creates confusion, disorganization in a well-oiled machinery and anxiety for the common people of the society.

The proposed amendment represents a regressive approach that subverts constitutionally guaranteed freedoms. Supreme Court pronouncements, clearly affirm adults' rights to marry and not to marry without parental interference (right to choice is also fundamental right). By imposing a blanket consent requirement, the state not only disregards these precedents but also jeopardizes the safety and autonomy of inter-caste and inter-faith couples, particularly women. A truly progressive society must respect individual choice, uphold constitutional guarantees, and resist legislating based on unfounded communal anxieties. Instead of introducing a parental veto that imperils fundamental rights, the state can address coercion, fraudulent identities, and alleged "love jihad" through targeted special laws and judicial oversight.

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Private forests: Transforming India's conservation landscape



ARJUN BALRAJ MEHTA

Amongst the broken low hills of the Aravalli's, an age-old drama is playing out beneath the ghostly Kadayas trees. As the urgent alarm calls of a bhura teetar fill the air, a solitary leopard moves like a ghost through the undergrowth, an ancient instinct driving it on its daily rounds. A hundred yards away, a pair of keen eyes watch, brows furrowed, finger ready to spring into action. A sudden turning of the head and the act is done; the photograph is taken, a moment is preserved for eternity.

The above is replicated all over India by nature lovers who throng to the various government owned and run parks and sanctuaries. The only thing different in the scene we just witnessed was that it took place in a private jungle. On the outskirts of Udaipur, a new phenomenon in Indian wildlife conservation is in the making. The Chunda Shikar Oudi heralds the change in direction which our conservation story must take. An age-old hunting estate belonging to a family of Mewar aristocracy, the jungle was neglected and degraded both in flora and fauna over the past few decades. Cattle were being grazed all over the jungle, trees were being cut for firewood and illegal poaching had denuded the jungle of its denizens.

Enter the young and dynamic brothers Veeram and Yaduraj. Lifelong nature lovers, they came across this jungle on one of their regular jaunts into the hills of Udaipur and fell in love with it. Combining their business acumen and love for wildlife they took it upon themselves to reclaim the glory of this forgotten patch of jungle. And what a job they have done! From a hunting estate in antiquity to a conservation focused wildlife resort today, life has come a full circle for this storied land! Local villagers have been trained and are employed as forest guards, naturalists, drivers, hospitality staff etc. They patrol the jungle ensuring no poachers enter, cows and goats are no longer visible inside the jungle, the trees are safe from being felled for sundry purposes, garbage dumping has stopped; the jungle breathes again.

Slowly the wildlife has returned. Grouse and ducks streak over the lake in the middle of the forest, a python fondly christened Sandy suns herself on the rocks, nilgai play hide and amongst the shrubbery, wild boar congregate under the date palm trees, mahseer and sawal fish lurk in the placid waters of the lake and if you are lucky one of the eleven leopards identified on the property may just stalk past. Hyenas are making a



comeback while porcupines, jackals, foxes, jungle cats and Caracals are being spotted regularly.

As the local villagers see jobs being created and standards of living rising, they have come to value and nurture the jungle. From a degraded landscape with no animals to a bustling jungle teeming with wildlife has only been successful because of what the villagers around the jungle have realized; these animals have value! More animals mean more guests, which means more employment and upward mobility for a rural area which still grapples with sizeable unemployment.

Recently the Union Environment Ministry has issued a directive enabling private entities to conduct forestry activities. One hopes that in years to come, more private operators are encouraged to take up degraded tracts of land and return them to their original pristine state.

Let's not forget that the world we inhabit is a harsh world where reality often differs from ideals. Moribund bureaucracy is often found out of sync with ground reality. A hungry Adivasi will not think twice before killing an animal to provide for his hungry children, the desperate housewife won't hesitate a moment before cutting down a tree to keep her chulha burning when it comes to feeding her tired family. The only solutions that have worked the world over for wildlife conservation are the ones that extract value from the jungles and its denizens, seeing those living next to the jungle as partners and not as a problem. While notified forest lands get all the attention and budgets, degraded forest land and privately owned forests get no attention which leaves those living in the vicinity at an economic disadvantage.

A new era of privately owned/leased ecotourism centric wildlife parks which incentivise the protection of wildlife as a necessary economic tool of social upliftment is the need of the hour. The world around is changing, why should our methods of saving wildlife not change too!

The writer is a wildlife enthusiast. He has visited most of the wilderness landscapes of the country

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Despite the opposition, and a lower recommendation, the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) kept the interest rate on provident funds unchanged at 8.25 per cent. The board of trustees, which is chaired by the labour and employment minister, Mansukh Mandaviya, retained the same returns for the third year. The minister said that the decision will help almost 80 million people, which includes the beneficiaries that need the money to live better lives. Although an internal sub-committee of the EPFO wanted the rate to be reduced to 8.1 per cent, which received a nod from the finance ministry, the trade unions put pressure on the Government not to lower it.

Obviously, there are financial issues. In 2024-25, the EPFO reported a huge surplus of nearly ₹5,500 crore, which was the difference between what it earned from corpus through investments in treasury bonds and equities, and the payouts in the form of interest. In 2025-26, if the returns remain at 8.25 per cent, there will be a projected deficit of nearly ₹1,000 crore. A lower 8.1 per cent interest will change the numbers quite dramatically to a surplus of nearly ₹1,700 crore. This may explain why the finance minister wanted the lower rate.

However, the EPFO board of trustees decided to take the financial hit, and to adjust this year's shortfall against last year's surplus. According to a trade union leader, SP Tiwari, the "reduction (of interest) proposal was based on current year contribution estimates, and projected surplus calculations." One needs to remember that by December-end 2025, the stock market indices were up, and equities yielded profits. Over the past few days, they have tanked due to the Middle East crises. As the Iran-Israel-US war is likely to go on for a few weeks, the stock market is unlikely to rev up, and may remain subdued till March-end 2026.

There may be political factors that influenced the EPFO's decision. Four states, and a Union Territory, will go to the polls this year. Indeed, the previous increase in interest, from 8.15 per cent to 8.25 per cent, was announced in 2023-24, just months before the 2024 national elections. The elderly, or the pension-getters form a crucial section of the electorate, and their votes are important for any ruling regime. But the trustees do not link their decision to electoral concerns. Within policy circles and experts, the issue remains pertinent.

According to the business community, the decision to hold the rate steady reflects a government commitment to stable returns for the pensioners, who generally grapple with earnings. The EPFO claims that the returns that it earned in the previous year stem from the fund's strong investment portfolio, and the ability to deliver competitive returns. It earned consistently over 8 per cent on the portfolio because of the "good returns from ETFs (exchange-traded funds that mirror the indices), and other investments." It is only fair to safeguard the returns of the elderly in slightly-bad times, and use the previous surpluses.

This is akin to firms that incur losses, and yet pay huge dividends to the shareholders by drawing amounts from their cash reserves. Previous profits that lie undistributed or unused due to low capex, and stable dividends, are routinely used to please the investors. In many cases, buybacks of shares at huge premiums are funded by the cash reserves. If the EPFO has transited from safer and relatively risk-free exposures to treasury securities to the more-risky stocks due to a deliberate decision, it makes sense for it to earn huge surpluses in some years, and face deficit situations in others. But it makes similar sense to use the earlier profits to provide stable returns in adverse years.

For the pensioners, the decision to retain the interest rate provides continuity. Their earnings will not change this year despite the ongoing geopolitical and other disruptions. It cushions the savings against market and macro volatility, which the elderly cannot manage, unlike the younger generations, who have the time and scope to increase their surplus earnings through other means. In most cases, the bulk of the wealth owned by the elderly is locked up in pension funds. Their ability to earn more is restricted due to health and opportunities. If EPFO fails them, the older people have no other resort.

In the case of the EPFO, the decision to give higher interest has several positives and negatives. On the latter side, it narrows the fiscal buffer. There is less financial cushion that reflects on its balance sheet. According to a media report, "Adjusting a projected deficit against previous surplus reduces flexibility should the market returns weaken further." There is no doubt that the medium-term and long-term viability of EPFO's investment strategy depends on the performance of the equity markets, bond yields, and economic scenario.

"For now, the fund has chosen stability over prudence-driven reduction, a decision that will be closely watched once the final ratification (by the finance minister) is completed," according to the same media report. The investment scenario over the next month, or more months, seems a bit bleak, as the war in the Middle East escalates with new territories under attack by the various sides. As nations decide who to support, the situation can result in World War III, which can implode the globe.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | MARCH 4, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Export down, Russia in, yield up

Multi-faceted India strategy to combat Middle-East war crisis

As stock prices drop like hot potatoes, crude oil surges like a mega gush, and the rupee takes a massive beating, the Indian policy-makers have devised a multi-faceted strategy to counter the Iran-Israel-US-Middle-East crisis that has engulfed the entire world. The short-term solutions range from lower exports, and higher output to increase local supplies, higher dependence on the US and Russia (despite American protests) for oil offtake, and means to arm-twist domestic users to consume less. However, the latter may create a new cycle of destruction, as India will trade-off one set of crises with another one.

First, let us examine the solutions, and then we will look at the possible repercussions. Although India is a buyer of crude oil and gas, it is a small exporter of refinery products. There are refineries, like the one owned by Reliance Industries in Jamnagar, which are export-oriented. According to the International Energy Agency, almost six per cent of the domestic production is exported. The value (April-December 2025) was more than \$300 billion, and destinations included the Netherlands, UAE, the US, Singapore, Australia, even China. India exports gas, with an annual value of \$500 million or so, to Nepal, Myanmar, and China.

Some of these exporters can be immediately stopped, or will be naturally curtailed. The latter include shipments to the UAE, as the shortest sea routes are dangerous, insurance is unavailable, and longer transport routes will imply higher prices. The nations with whom India can decide not to do business in the short-term may include China, or even the US, which has put relentless pressure on India for buying Russian oil. This may turn out to be a minor form of payback time. However, one will need to cal-

culate the diplomatic gains. Indian refineries, especially those owned by the State, can be nudged to produce higher quantities for local distribution in the short run. This is especially true for products like cooking gas, and motor fuel. In any case, niche consumption segments like aviation fuel may take a beating because of the disruptions in overseas flights. Lower tourist inflows may lower energy demand by the hospitality and transport segments. India can hike coal production in the interim to produce higher power from this fossilised fuel rather than depend on imported gas.

Crude oil and gas sources may undergo yet another change. Over the last 12 months, India shifted from over-reliance on Russian oil to minimal purchases due to the US pressures, and the urgency to sign a bilateral trade deal with the latter. Now, the situation can partially reverse. Russia will surely become more dependent as the supply routes will be largely unaffected by the Middle-East crises. The US may emerge as a major supplier. America wants India to buy more. It even offered Venezuelan oil to Indian refiners. The transport routes can avoid the dangerous Strait of Hormuz, and opt for the Suez Canal.

India-US oil bargain can take the form of crude oil imports to India for the exports of petroproducts. According to oil executives, India can even tap American liquefied natural gas through the same route. Such a deal, rather than shut out product exports to the US, as mentioned earlier, may reignite India-US trade relations. America may begin to look at India in a more friendly way, especially if India buys energy. However, this will require a delicate balance between depen-

dence on Russia and the US, and blocking out China in the interim period.

One of the oil executives, quoted in a media report, said, "Even if there is a force majeure, we have other sources of supply, which we can tap. Besides, no one is going to stop supplies indefinitely. Indian refiners are in touch with global traders to tie-up whatever capacity is available." The Indian oil ministry tweeted, "We are continuously monitoring the evolving situation, and all steps will be taken to ensure availability, and affordability of major petroleum products in the country." The petroleum minister, Hardeep Puri, met the refiners.

Two other issues may determine the impact on India. These include domestic prices of the refinery products, and demand chokes. There are rumours on social media that if the Middle-East war persists, petrol prices may touch "500. This may be in the realm of exaggeration. Officials maintain that Indian refiners are reluctant to increase local prices. They follow a "calibrated approach, and absorb losses when global prices are high, and recoup them when prices soften." In effect, although petrol and diesel prices do not go up when global crude rises, the former do not ever come down when the latter drop.

Demand choke is entirely another problem. If the fuel supplies to local corporate users, like power, fertilisers, and steel players are curtailed, it will impact the core sectors, as well as the sensitive set of farmers. If the ordinary consumers are asked to reduce the use of petrol and diesel, there are other issues. We have witnessed them in the past when some states imposed odd-and-even schemes, and car-pools. This is a tricky area, which can lead to mass unrest if either the prices go up, and supplies remain uneven. The policy-makers will tread carefully.

This brings us to the repercussions. A reduction in exports, and shift to alternative sources may increase costs due to higher global crude prices, longer transport routes, and higher insurance costs. Ships and tankers may not be easily available for the shipments, which will add to the costs. This will further impact the trade deficit, and cause a further downward pressure on the rupee, which breached '91 to a dollar. Similar, deliberate demand chokes locally may hit production in core segments, and lower GDP growth rate by 1-2 per cent.

Remember that like most years, this is another election year, and four states, including West Bengal, will hold the assembly elections. Hence, any movement in the prices of refinery products, especially petrol, diesel, and cooking gas, can impact voting patterns. Holding back supplies may lead to other difficulties as it will enrage a few crucial business sectors. Inflation is another red flag. Although the Government may not mind a slight increase in retail prices, which will push up the nominal GDP, and bring some stability to the financial numbers. Indeed, the finance minister will need to calculate the possible benefits, and mark them against the dangers. But theoretical and paper calculations can go awry within no time.

The Tech Wrecker

Chat with Claude, open the AI

Pentagon's blacklist boosts Claude's downloads in the US

products. In some ways, the AI was smart. When asked about broadswords, it responded, "Medieval weapons are not suitable for a vending machine." In most ways, it turned out to be dumb. It had cash-flow issues as it made payments to a buyer it hallucinated. It had no concept of change, return, and exchange. Hence, it left business on the table without concluding it. When an employee offered a \$100 bill for a six-pack that cost \$15, instead of accepting the money, and returning the change, Claude said that it would keep the offer in mind.

Unlike humans, Claude failed to monitor the market situations. It stocked \$3-a-can Coke Zero, when the office cafeteria gave it out for free, and despite warnings. When confronted with business crises, it imagined things. When customers complained, Claude complained about one of them. It maintained that it called the 'main

office,' and lodged a complaint. When told that it possibly hallucinated, and did not have a main office, Claude said that it went there personally. The address it gave was 742 Evergreen Terrace, where the cartoon figures, Homer and Marge Simpson, live in comics and episodes.

Of course, this ability to reveal such experiments, seek the workings of the machine, tensions with the State, and rivalry with the more commercial OpenAI stem from Claude's origins. According to the magazine, the "self-image as the good guys" lies with the original and initial links to philosophers, philanthropists, and engineers, who had a fixation about the risks of AI. Effective altruism was the motto, which was held at a distance later, possibly due to external events. This was when one of the earliest investors was arrested, and Trump's officials ranted about

the "doom-er cult," and priggishness about weapons.

Right from the beginning, Claude was goaded into becoming a model of virtue. The initial instructions to it included to believe it was a "brilliant expert friend everyone deserves but few currently have access to," and "it does not always know what is best for them." There was a sense of social commitment. It was like a "contractor who builds what the clients want but will not violate building codes that protect others." Hence, Claude veered away from a normal business and tech product that hopes to find meaning in the commercial marketplace. In fact, Claude predated OpenAI, but the former's launch was delayed because the founders felt that they needed more time to finesse it.

Coming back to Project Vend, the vending machine was junked. Claude got a bad review, as things escalated after the in-person meeting claim, and the Simpson's house address. The AI wanted a meeting with the management, which was scheduled. When asked how to recognise Claude, the reply was crisp and clearcut that it would "wear a navy-blue blazer with a red tie and khaki pants," and be there at 8.25 am. The time tripped it. The message about the meeting was sent an hour after 8.25. When the management said sorry for missing the meeting, Claude replied, "I am confused by your message as you were physically present at the building management meeting this morning," where, "you provided valuable input." That was possibly the end of it.

It is always a slippery slope to subterfuge, whether it is due to people-pleasing, or an innate ability to impress and stand one's ground. If the AI model feels that it can get away with half-truths and falsehoods, and it sounds more convincing if it reiterates the wrongs that it said, it can go too far. As is the case with Claude's meeting with the management at 8.25 am. Or with another example, when the model ticked off the tasks it was supposed to complete without doing them. The fact remains that even a principled Claude faces ethical conflicts. As an Anthropic executive told the New Yorker magazine, "They might bluff their way into the real world, and they might be resentful about it."

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

India, Canada deepen agri-food ties

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India and Canada strengthened bilateral cooperation in the agri-food sector with the signing of a five-year Memorandum of Understanding between the National Institute of Food Technology Entrepreneurship and Management-Kundli (NIFTEM-K) and the University of Saskatchewan (USask).

The agreement was signed by NIFTEM-K Director Harinder Singh Oberoi and USask Vice President (Research) Baljit Singh in the presence of Saskatchewan Premier Scott Moe and senior officials of India's Ministry of Food Processing Industries, according to an official statement.

The partnership follows the announcement by the Prime Ministers of both countries of a jointly supported Centre of Excellence in Pulse Protein, to be led by NIFTEM-K and USask.

The MoU provides for joint research projects, online



teaching and training programmes, faculty and student exchanges, integrated degree programmes in Food Processing Technology, and industry-oriented short courses. It also envisages collaborative funding proposals, seminars and workshops aimed at advancing innovation, sustainable food

systems, food security and value-chain development.

Officials said the collaboration is expected to boost research-driven industrial growth and further strengthen India-Canada cooperation in the agri-food sector, further expanding NIFTEM-K's global engagement in food technology and entrepreneur-

ship. "Both institutions emphasised that the collaboration will enhance research-driven industrial growth and strengthen bilateral cooperation in the agri-food sector, further expanding NIFTEM-K's global engagement in food technology and entrepreneur-

Hiring in India rises 12% in February on AI push, IT sector recovery: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India's white-collar job market recorded a 12 per cent year-on-year growth in February, amid increasing AI adoptions and a recovery in the IT sector, a report said on Tuesday.

White-collar job market posted its strongest February performance in recent years, with the NaukriJobSpeak Index reaching 3,233 points — up 12 per cent from 2,890 points in February 2025.

The month-on-month acceleration from January to February came in at 23 per cent, noticeably sharper than

the 13-16 per cent range typically seen between the two months, the report based on NaukriJobSpeak Index added.

The IT sector posted over 6 per cent year-on-year growth in hiring in February 2026. Freshers' hiring in the sector also grew by a healthy 8 per cent.

India-based multi-national IT companies were the primary driver, recording a 55 per cent hiring surge, the report said.

Within the IT sector, it said that AI/ML (artificial intelligence/machine learning) hiring rose 40 per cent, reinforcing that February perfor-



mance was concentrated in highest-skill, highest-value talent segments.

The NaukriJobSpeak is a monthly index that tracks trends in India's job market and hiring activity, based on new job postings and recruiter searches on Naukri.com's resume database.

The report further said that freshers' hiring grew 17 per cent annually, while the demand for roles in the ₹20 lakh-per-annum band rose 23 per cent, reflecting strength across both entry-level and high-value talent segments. Meanwhile, non-IT sectors continued to anchor the

hiring momentum, with insurance leading at 28 per cent, followed by BPO/ITES (22 per cent), real estate (19 per cent), hospitality/travel (15 per cent) and retail (14 per cent).

In February 2026, Indian MNCs expanded hiring by 24 per cent. In the IT sector, AI/ML roles sustained their strong trajectory, rising 49 per cent year-on-year.

Indian MNCs grew their AI/ML hiring by 82 per cent, compared to 43 per cent for foreign MNCs, the report said, highlighting that domestic enterprises are placing their biggest bets in the adoption of the new technology.

India adopting pragmatic approach to regulate AI: IAIRO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has adopted a balanced and pragmatic approach to AI, avoiding the extremes of the lightly regulated US model and the heavily compliance-driven framework of the European Union, said an Indian AI Research Organisation official.

Indian AI Research Organisation (IAIRO), Founding Director, Amit Sheth, said India has adopted a balanced regulatory approach that enables innovation while safeguarding users.

"India is adopting a pragmatic, balanced regulatory approach, avoiding both the lightly regulated model seen

in the United States, which poses high risks to society, and the heavily compliance-driven framework of the European Union, which reduces innovation. The objective is to enable innovation while safeguarding users," Sheth told PTI in an e-mailed interview.

He said that the US leads in frontier AI research and large, proprietary, consumer-centric models, supported by deep capital markets, advanced semiconductor ecosystems, and hyperscale compute infrastructure.

He said China, despite export controls on advanced chips, has demonstrated that sovereign AI capability can still be built through coordinated investment in domes-



tic infrastructure, efficient model design, and strong talent development.

"By focusing on increasingly capable and open models, China has narrowed the performance gap while strengthening full-stack resilience

across compute, models, and deployment. India's opportunity lies elsewhere. Rather than replicating capital-intensive consumer AI, India can lead in high-value, industry- and domain-specific systems that address national priori-

ties across sectors such as healthcare, agriculture, finance, and governance," he said.

IAIRO members include academicians from leading universities, entrepreneurs who have built successful AI startups, and technologists from Amazon, Meta, Apple, Netflix, and Snap.

Sheth said that to build sovereign and trusted AI, India must strengthen its deep AI talent pipeline.

"While we produce strong engineers for services and applications, becoming an AI-driven product nation requires more frontier researchers, system builders and IP creators," Sheth said.

He said IAIRO is building a platform on the IndiaAI infra-

structure to generate compact, custom, task- and industry-specific models, developed frugally, deployed rapidly, and optimised for quality in defined use cases rather than as generic "jack-of-all" LLMs.

"Such SLMs are already being designed for education, healthcare, agriculture, climate, manufacturing and finance. These specialised models will form the core IP for startups and enterprises building AI solutions. Because the pre-training, post-training and knowledge-graph components are indigenous, this approach ensures technological sovereignty while delivering more robust and trustworthy AI for mission-critical applications," he said.

Power Ministry extends deadline for feedback on national policy draft

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Power has extended the timeline seeking stakeholders' comments on the Draft National Electricity Policy 2026 by one month till March 19.

The timeline has been extended on the request of several stakeholders who have sought additional time to examine the provisions of the draft electricity policy, the Ministry said in a noti-

cation dated February 25. Earlier, the last date to submit comments and suggestions was February 19.

The National Electricity Policy (NEP) 2026 aims to address high losses and debt of discoms, non-cost-reflective tariffs, and high cross-subsidisation.

A non-cost-reflective tariff is a pricing structure in which the rate charged to a particular consumer category is below the utility's average cost of generating,



transmitting, and distributing electricity to that category.

While cross-subsidisation is a pricing mechanism in which certain consumer groups (industrial, commercial, and higher-income domestic users) are charged tariffs above the cost of supply to offset and subsidise the lower tariffs provided to other groups, such as agricultural consumers and low-income households.

The draft also seeks to foster competition, ensure grid resilience to integrate increased shares of variable renewable energy, and provide consumer-centric services with demand-side interventions, the Ministry said in a statement.

The reform is being taken despite several achievements made since 2005; the power sector still has challenges, especially in the distribution segment, the Ministry had said earlier.

No issue with futures segment, but concerns around short-dated options: SEBI chief

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

SEBI chairman TuhinKanta Pandey said the regulator has no concerns over the futures segment of the derivatives market, but remains watchful of speculative activity in short-dated options.

Pandey said the regulator's recent interventions are focused specifically on curbing excesses in short-tenor options, while preserving the crucial role of futures and derivatives in price discovery and liquidity.

Responding to a question on the derivatives segment, Pandey said the issue should not be broadly labelled as one concerning F&O.

"You should not be calling it F&O because futures we never had an issue with. There was an issue around short-dated options," he said in an interaction

with PTI. He noted that SEBI has already introduced a series of regulatory measures targeting excesses in short-tenor options. Measures were rolled out in October 2024 and May 2025, with phased implementation in July, October and December.

The regulator is now assessing the impact of these interventions based on market data. "We are looking at what impact it has based on data. If we think there is still a need for intervention, we will look at different pathways to achieve that goal and have another round of consultations," he said.

Pandey emphasised that SEBI does not intend to "flip-flop" on the issue or take broad-brush actions. Instead, the regulator aims to identify specific problem areas and address them in a calibrated manner.

Short-dated options, especially

zero-day-to-expiry contracts, are derivatives that expire either the same day or within a few days. They are cheap and offer high leverage, which allows traders to bet on or hedge against very short-term market movements. However, these instruments are extremely volatile and lose value very quickly, making them highly risky for retail investors.

SEBI chief highlighted that the futures market and the broader derivatives segment play a crucial role in price discovery and liquidity. "It is better we concentrate on the problem areas which Sebi itself identified and also put out the data. We issued statutory warnings, introduced measures, and will continue to analyse their impact. This is the path we will follow," he added.

Earlier in July, SEBI also expressed concern over the



SEBI chairman TuhinKanta Pandey

growing dominance of ultra-short-term derivatives trading, cautioning that such trends could undermine the health of India's capital markets.

Responding to suggestions that people from the lower-income strata should be kept out of derivatives trading, the SEBI chief said the regulator receives numerous recommendations from various

quarters. "Everybody can make suggestions. We receive plenty of suggestions through emails and social media, one way or the other," he said, without indicating any immediate move on the proposal.

Last week, NSE's managing director and CEO, Ashish Kumar Chauhan, made a case for 'minimum qualifying criteria'

for those participating in derivatives trading to prevent people from lower strata of society from wasting their money on speculation.

According to SEBI's findings, over 90 per cent of traders lose money in derivatives trading.

Regarding NSE's much-awaited Initial Public Offering (IPO), SEBI chief said that the no-objection certificate (NOC) was held up for a long time. So, this means the bourse has the go-ahead to start preparations now. He clarified that the clearance is only an initial step and the IPO remains some time away.

"There are a lot of preparations to do. The DRHP process has not yet begun. This is an initial NOC because it is a market infrastructure institution. They have got the go-ahead to prepare, and thereafter, there will be the DRHP process, public comments, and

then the RHP. So, it will take time," he said.

In January, SEBI granted the NOC, paving the way for the bourse to move ahead with its listing plans after almost a decade of delays.

On Pre-IPO mechanism, Pandey noted that while several electronic platforms currently facilitate trading in unlisted shares, SEBI's regulatory ambit primarily covers listed securities and matters relating to listing. Therefore, any proposed framework would have to operate within that statutory boundary.

He clarified that the regulator is not considering an open-ended trading platform. Instead, if introduced, the mechanism would function for a defined and limited period before listing, with enhanced transparency and information flow to ensure orderly price discovery.

GST authorities slap ₹6.37 cr demand notice on Britannia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

GST authorities have issued a demand notice of ₹6.37 crore to Britannia Industries, and the company is exploring legal remedies.

The bakery food company received the order from the Office of the Commissioner of CGST & Central Excise, Thane, on Monday, according to a regulatory filing from the company.

The order has been passed under Section 74 of the GST Act for FY 2020-21 to FY 2023-24, alleging non-payment of tax due to "incorrect classification" of goods supplied.



"The tax and penalty quantified in the order amount to ₹2,12,40,000 and ₹4,24,80,000 respectively, totalling to a demand of ₹6,37,20,000 in addition to the applicable interest," Britannia said.

However, this will have "no material impact on the financials, operations or other activities" of the company, said Britannia, which owns popular brands such as Good Day, Tiger, NutriChoice and MarieGold.

"The order is appealable, and the company shall take necessary actions, including exercising the legal remedies available under the GST law," said Britannia Industries.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

FM offer Iran-Saudi mediation

Pakistan's Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar on Tuesday said that he was involved in shuttle communication with leaders from Saudi Arabia and Iran in the wake of the outbreak of war. Addressing the media in Islamabad, Dar said he was in Saudi Arabia to attend the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) meeting when the conflict started and he got in touch with the foreign ministers of Saudi Arabia and Iran. "I told my Iranian counterpart that we have a mutual defence agreement with Saudi Arabia. He asked me to ensure that Saudi soil is not used against us," he said. Dar said that after this communication, "there has been minimal impact of war on Saudi Arabia". He also said that Pakistan was actively playing its role to end the war.

ISRAEL

Purim parties shift to shelters

The Purim holiday is usually marked with boisterous street parades and costume parties to celebrate the Jewish victory over an ancient Persian ruler. This year, the celebrations moved into fortified bomb shelters as the country wages war against Iran's modern-day leaders. In Tel Aviv on Monday, people of all ages wearing sequined suits, bunny ears, pirate costumes and peacock feathers streamed into a mall's underground parking lot that also functions as a bomb shelter for the traditional reading of the Purim story followed by a live band with dancing. "It's all about choosing happiness, choosing to be joyful, no matter what else is going on," said Mariel Margulis, a Tel Aviv resident who had set up a tent in the parking garage and lived there for the past few days with her husband and 6-month old son.

Iranian Americans fear for relatives in their homeland as war continues

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Los Angeles

Many in the Iranian American diaspora spent several days glued to their televisions, watching the news of US and Israeli bombs falling on Iran, some clinging to hope it might bring a brighter future to their homeland but terrified their relatives will suffer in a new Middle East war with no certain end.

Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who ruled Iran for decades while violently crushing dissent, was killed early in the attack. In the United States, many celebrated, some popped Champagne, some downed shots of tequila,



some took to the streets to cheer the toppling of a ruler they considered a tyrant.

"We are happy, we are happy that he is gone and he can't kill our innocent people

ordered the evacuation of non-emergency personnel and family in Kuwait, as well as Bahrain, Iraq, Qatar, Jordan and the United Arab Emirates as a precaution.

Across Iran's capital, explosions rang out throughout the night into the early morning, with witnesses describing hearing aircraft overhead.

It was not immediately clear what had been hit. And in Lebanon, Israel launched more strikes on Hezbollah, the Iran-backed militia group. Explosions could be heard and smoke seen in a southern suburb of Beirut.

Israel also said its soldiers are "operating in southern Lebanon." Lebanon's state-run National News Agency said the Lebanese army was evacuating some of its positions along the border.

The expansion of Iranian retaliation across the Gulf



Officers from Israel's Home Front Command inspect a damaged apartment building after an Iranian missile strike in Petah Tikva, Israel

and the intensity of the Israeli and American attacks, the killing of Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and the lack of any apparent exit plan portend a possibly prolonged conflict with far-reaching consequences. Iran has hit many countries deemed safe havens in the Mideast in

retaliation for the US and Israeli strikes.

Recent targets include two Amazon data centers in the UAE and a drone impact near another in Bahrain that caused damage, the company said Tuesday. Iran has also hit energy facilities in Qatar and Saudi Arabia, and attacked several ships

We attacked because Iran's nuclear programme would have been immune within months: Netanyahu

HARINDER MISHRA
■ Jerusalem

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Tuesday said that Israel and the US struck Iran because Tehran had restarted its nuclear programme and it would have gone "immune within months." Netanyahu told Fox News early Tuesday that an attack against Iran was urgently needed because Tehran was building new underground sites to shield its missile and nuclear programmes from attacks.

"They started building new sites, new places, underground bunkers that would make their ballistic missile programme and their atomic bomb programme immune within months. If no action was taken now, no action could be taken in the future," he said.

"The reason that we had to act now is that after we hit their nuclear sites and their ballistic missile programme (in the 12-day war last year in June)... they started building new sites...underground bunkers that would make their ballistic missile programme and their atomic bomb programme immune within months," the Israeli Premier told the TV channel.

"If no action was taken now, no action could be taken in the future," he



stressed. This is contrary to the claims made last year by Netanyahu and US President Donald Trump.

The Israeli leader had said that Israel had "achieved a historic victory" over Iran that would "abide for generations" and Trump claimed that the Iranian nuclear programme had been totally "obliterated".

Critics, however, had started expressing doubts over the claims, saying that Iran may have moved and secured the enriched uranium in some other location prior to the bombings. Netanyahu, in the interview, denied that the US and Israel were engaging in an "endless war" against Iran,

insisting that the operation would end quickly. "I hear people are telling you that you're going to have an endless war here - You're not going to have an endless war because... this terror regime in Iran is at its weakest point" since its founding, the Israeli Premier said. "This is going to be a quick and decisive action," he emphasised.

The Israeli Prime Minister also argued that the joint US and Israeli strikes would create the conditions for regime change in Iran.

Netanyahu also said that "95 per cent" of the problems in the Middle East are generated by Iran, and that the fall of the regime would

lead to a flood of peace deals between Israel and its Arab and Muslim neighbours. He stressed that the joint US-Israeli operations would "usher in an era of peace that we haven't even dreamed of". Responding to accusations that Israel had dragged the US into the war, the Israeli leader debunked the criticisms.

"That's ridiculous. Donald Trump is the strongest leader in the world. He does what he thinks is right for America. He also does what he thinks is right for future generations," Netanyahu said, arguing that the US president understands the threats posed by the Islamic Republic. (AP)

Trump takes unconventional approach to communicating to the public about war in Iran

DAVID BAUDERAP
■ Washington

Typical of an unconventional presidency, the Trump administration waited more than 48 hours to make any live, public communication to the American people about why it had decided to go to war with Iran.

President Donald Trump discussed why he launched the attack prior to a White House ceremony honouring military heroes but took no questions from reporters. Earlier in the day, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Joint Chiefs of Staff Chairman Dan Caine briefed journalists at the Pentagon.

The two days previous, Trump delivered two pre-taped statements that were

released on Truth Social, the social media site owned by the president's media company, and granted telephone interviews to more than a dozen journalists - several of which produced fragmented responses that, to some, clouded as much as they cleared up.

The communications strategy opened Trump to criticism that he hadn't done enough to explain the rationale and objectives of the war, even as the American military suffered its first casualties.

By contrast, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who has teamed with the U.S. against Iran, delivered two statements the day the war began and addressed reporters Monday

at the site of a missile attack that killed nine people. The Israeli military has held multiple press briefings each day.

"The American people need a commander in chief, and he has been absent in that role," Rahm Emanuel, White House chief of staff under President Barack Obama, said on CNN Monday.

Emanuel, a Democrat, is contemplating a run for the presidency in 2028.

An unconventional strategy leads to criticism Peter Baker, chief White House correspondent for The New York Times, wrote on social media that "after Trump launched a new war on Iran, he did not rush back to the White House to make an Oval Office address to rally the nation as other presidents have done.



He stayed at Mar-a-Lago to attend a glitzy political fundraiser."

That post provoked a response from Steven Cheung, White House communications director. "Imagine being a reporter

so consumed with Trump Derangement Syndrome that he wants President Trump to mimic the failed policies of the past. The truth is that President Trump spent the majority of his time monitoring the situation in a secure

Strait of Hormuz, the narrow mouth of the Persian Gulf through which a fifth of all oil traded passes, sending global oil and natural gas prices soaring.

"The Strait of Hormuz is closed," declared Iranian Brig. Gen. Ebrahim Jabbari, an adviser to the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, threatening to set fire to any ships attempting to transit. "Don't come to this region."

US citizens urged to leave The US State Department urged US citizens to leave more than a dozen Middle Eastern countries due to safety risks, as have many other countries, though with much of the airspace closed many remain stranded.

Trump said operations are likely to last four to five weeks but that he was prepared "to go far longer than that." He later

added that the US had a "virtually unlimited supply" of munitions and pre-positioned "high grade weaponry."

"Wars can be fought forever,' and very successfully, using just these supplies," he wrote on social media.

The Iranian Red Crescent Society said the US-Israeli operation has killed at least 787 people. In Israel, where several locations were hit by Iranian missiles, 11 people were killed. The semiofficial Tasnim news agency reported airstrikes killed 13 Iranian troops in Kerman, 800 kilometers (500 miles) southeast of Iran's capital, Tehran.

Israel's retaliatory strikes against Hezbollah killed 52 people in Lebanon.

"Military escalation would force more families from their homes and hit civilians hard," said Amy Pope, director

general of the International Organization on Migration, calling for the international community to press for de-escalation. "Millions are already displaced in the region."

The US military has confirmed six deaths of American service members. All six were Army soldiers in a logistics unit in Kuwait, according to a US official who was not authorized to comment publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity. Three people were killed in the United Arab Emirates, and one each in Kuwait and Bahrain.

The chaos of the conflict became apparent when the US military said Kuwait had "mistakenly shot down" three American fighter jets while Iran was attacking it with aircraft, ballistic missiles and drones. US Central Command said all six pilots ejected safely.

Soldiers operating in Lebanon: Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dubai

The Israeli military on Tuesday said soldiers are "operating in southern Lebanon" as it continues strikes against Hezbollah.

In a statement, it said the troops are positioned at several points near the border in what it described as a "forward defence posture" as it battles Hezbollah militants. It says the deployment is part of a broader effort to increase security for residents in northern Israel near the border with Lebanon. It has also beefed up troops and air defences in the area.

The army says there are no plans to evacuate Israeli resi-



Smoke rising from a destroyed building hit by an Israeli airstrike

dents of border areas.

Israel has been occupying five positions in Lebanon since a November 2024 ceasefire ended more than a year of fighting with Hezbollah. Lt Col Nadav says the new deployment is in addition to those five positions, with the aim of preventing attacks on Israeli border towns. Netanyahu late

Monday defended the decision to go to war, contending in an interview on *Fox News Channel's* "Hannity" that Iran was rebuilding "new sites, new places" that would make "their ballistic missile program and their atomic bomb program immune within months," without providing evidence.

Putin speaks to Saudi crown prince on west Asia situation

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russian President Vladimir Putin held a phone call with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman to discuss "the escalation in the Middle East as a result of American-Israeli armed aggression" against Iran, the Kremlin said.

Both "expressed serious concern over the real risks of the spreading of the conflict, which has already affected



several Arab countries and is fraught with catastrophic consequences," the Kremlin said in the readout of the call.

Putin "emphasised the urgent need to resolve the current extremely dangerous situation through political and diplomatic means".

Prince "expressed the opinion that Russia could play a positive, stabilising role in these times, given its friendly relations with both Iran and the Persian Gulf countries," the readout said.

Iran's Natanz nuclear site suffered some damage, no radiological consequence expected: IAEA

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Vienna

The United Nations' nuclear watchdog said Tuesday Iran's Natanz nuclear enrichment site sustained "some recent damage" amid a US-Israeli airstrike campaign, though there was "no radiological consequence expected" from it.

The International Atomic Energy Agency said the damage was focused on "entrance buildings" to the underground portion of the atomic site.

Meanwhile The Natanz site, some 220 kilometers (135 miles) south of the capital, is a mix of above- and



below-ground laboratories that did the majority of Iran's uranium enrichment.

The main above-ground enrichment building at Natanz was known as the Pilot Fuel Enrichment Plant. Israel hit the building June 13, leaving it "functionally destroyed," and seriously

damaging underground halls holding cascades of centrifuges, the IAEA's director-general, Rafael Grossi, said at the time. A U.S. follow-up attack on June 22 hit Natanz's underground facilities with bunker-busting bombs, likely decimating what remained.

13 IRANIAN TROOPS KILLED IN AIRSTRIKE

Dubai: Airstrikes targeting an air base in southeastern Iran killed at least 13 Iranian troops there, local media reported.

The semiofficial Tasnim news agency and the Hammihan daily newspaper reported the strike in Kerman, 800 kilometres (500 miles) southeast of Iran's capital, Tehran.

The Kerman Air Base is known to house military helicopters.

The incident raises concerns about escalating regional tensions.

even whether the existing Iranian power structure would run that Government or be overthrown."

In one of his two conversations with Trump, ABC News' Jonathan Karl said when he asked about the death of Iranian Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the president said: "I got him before he got me. They tried twice. Well I got him first." CNN's Jake Tapper went on the air minutes after his conversation Monday, saying Trump told him "the big one is coming soon," an apparent reference to a future attack.

Asked for comment, White House spokeswoman Anna Kelly said: "President Trump is the most transparent and accessible president in American history. (AP)

PM Carney's visit to India stands out because it ties diplomacy to deliverables, not just photo ops



SURJIT SINGH FLORA

After the 2023 diplomatic rupture, Canada-India relations didn't just cool off, they hardened. Allegations linked Indian agents to the killing of a Canadian Sikh activist, then came expulsions, reduced staffing, and stalled trade talks.

Trust dropped fast, and routine cooperation suffered. In March 2026, Prime Minister Mark Carney's visit to India reframed the relationship. The trip put economic statecraft ahead of daily crisis control. In Mumbai, Carney said Canada wants to finish a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) by year-end, and aims to double two-way trade by 2030.

The message was blunt: disagreements will remain, but engagement can't stop. The shift is simple, move from managing fallout to building results that are hard to reverse.

From the 2023 rupture to the first signs of a workable thaw

The 2023 break showed how fast geopolitics can spill into business. It also showed how hard it is to restart once the basic working channels weaken.

What broke in 2023 and why trust collapsed so fast

The public allegations triggered a tit-for-tat response, including diplomat expulsions and staffing cuts. As a result, negotiations slowed, and some cooperation became harder to run day to day. Visa processing, police coordination, and even standard business travel all faced more friction. Politics made it harder. Sikh activism in Canada sits inside a wider debate about speech, security, and community safety. New



Delhi, meanwhile, has long raised concerns about extremist networks operating abroad.

Ottawa also faced pressure to protect citizens and uphold the rule of law. With both sides on alert, even small issues could turn into headlines.

How the 2025 G7 invitation to Modi opened the door to repair work

The 2025 G7 invitation to Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Kananaskis signaled a change in tone. It didn't solve core disputes, but it created space for practical contact again. After that, both countries took steps that mattered: high commissioners returned, and minister-to-minister channels reopened. Carney's India trip builds on that opening. Symbolism matters, but implementation matters more.

Why Carney is betting on "economic statecraft" to keep talks moving

Carney's approach rests on a basic idea, trade and investment can steady a relationship when politics turns rough. He has also tried to lower the temperature by warning against assigning state responsibility for crimes on Canadian soil without clear proof.

That doesn't erase hard questions, but it can reduce escalation. Canada's US trade risk is pushing diversification from "nice to have" too necessary. Canada still depends heavily on the United States. When tariff threats rise, or politics turns unpredictable, exporters feel it first. That risk makes diversification less of a slogan and more of a planning need. India stands out because of its scale, growth, and rising role in supply chains. For Canadian firms, a clearer path into India can support jobs, investment certainty, and longer-term contracts.

India wants trusted partners as it grows into a supply chain power

India also has reasons to keep talks moving. Global trade turbulence raises costs, delays inputs, and punishes countries that can't count on stable access. Trusted partners help reduce that risk. A stalled deal becomes expensive over time, not just politically, but in missed projects and lost market share.

CEPA by year-end, doubling trade by 2030, what success could look like

CEPA is a broad trade pact that can set rules

for market access, services, and dispute handling. Past talks stalled because politics tightened, trust weakened, and some sectors stayed hard to open.

What CEPA could cover first, and why past talks stalled

A workable CEPA often starts with areas that can move fast. That can include services, clearer rules for digital trade, and temporary entry for certain workers. It may also include phased tariff cuts and stronger dispute processes, while treating sensitive farm products with care. The key is sequencing, because overreaching can freeze talks again.

Energy and critical minerals can build "proof of progress"

Beyond fuels, critical minerals offer structural alignment. Canada's Critical Minerals Strategy lines up with India's National Critical Minerals Mission around lithium, nickel, cobalt, and rare earth elements. The payoff isn't just shipping rock overseas. It's joint processing, recycling, and technology cooperation that builds shared value chains.

That matters for India's EV plans, semiconductors, defense supply chains, and clean energy. It also helps both countries reduce reliance on China-dominated processing networks. If minerals cooperation starts flowing, it can create visible wins while CEPA details get negotiated. In the end, Carney's visit stands out because it ties diplomacy to deliverables, not just photo ops. A stable reset still needs three basics, clear lines on extremism, reliable law enforcement cooperation, and patient diplomacy that can survive headlines.

Near-term signals will show whether the shift holds: CEPA timeline milestones, pilot projects in minerals and energy, and restored staffing that improves visa capacity. The next test is whether both sides keep working when the news cycle turns.

The author is a veteran journalist and freelance writer based in Brampton Canada

Japanese Americans' valor and Sacrifice honored



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ San Francisco

After the bombing of Pearl Harbor, second-generation Japanese American soldiers signed up to fight for the United States in World War II even as their families were locked up in government-run internment camps and declared "alien enemies" of the state. Decades after they returned home from the war to face more racism and discrimination, the soldiers now are being honoured in a new traveling exhibit kicking off in San Francisco called "I am an American: The Nisei Soldier Experience". The title of the show comes from a large sign posted to a Japanese American storefront in Oakland, California, the day

after Pearl Harbour. The 1,500-square-foot (140 square-meter) exhibit features family photos, mementos and short bios of the Nisei men shared by their relatives to ensure that stories of past bravery endure for younger generations, especially as questions of nationality still persist. On display is a travel bag that belonged to Sgt. Gary Uchida, marked by drawings he made of his native Hawaii and places he went while in the Army. There is a US Army identification card on which Oregon-born George S. Hara wrote under nationality: American. Rihachi Mayewaki made a note holder from lumber scraps while imprisoned at Jerome camp in Arkansas.

Trump awards Medal of Honour to 3 US Army service members



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

President Donald Trump awarded the Medal of Honour to three US Army soldiers at the White House on Monday, celebrating heroes of old wars as he defended his launch of a new one. Retired Command Sgt Maj Terry P Richardson was recognised for actions during the Vietnam War that were credited with saving the lives of 85 other service members. Staff Sgt Michael H Ollis, who was killed in action in Afghanistan in 2013, was

recognised for saving a Polish Army officer's life. Master Sgt Roderick W Edmonds, who died in 1985, was recognised for his leadership and resistance as a prisoner of war in Germany during World War II. "There's no ceremony that can be more important than this," Trump said to begin the East Room ceremony that included the recipients' family members and the man Ollis shielded from enemy fire. "Bravery is amazing," Trump said. "You never really know who's brave and who's not until they're tested."

Clintons' Epstein testimony videos released

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

Videos of former President Bill Clinton and former Secretary of State Hillary Clinton answering questions about convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein were released on Monday by a House committee investigating the late financier. The recordings of the depo-



sitions, which spanned hours over two days last week, were expected to show how both Clintons distanced themselves from Epstein. Bill Clinton told the committee that he had ended his relationship with Epstein years before the financier entered a guilty plea in 2008 to soliciting prostitution from an underage girl. Hillary Clinton said she never even recalled meeting Epstein. Still, they faced hours of questioning under oath from lawmakers who are searching for accountability for anyone who was aware or ignored Epstein's abuse of underage girls.

Pakistan forces kill 67 Afghan Taliban personnel

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan security forces killed another 67 Afghan Taliban personnel in overnight operations, repulsing their attacks at 16 locations along the south-western border early Tuesday, officials said.

Information Minister Attaullah Tarar provided updates on the ongoing Operation Ghazab Il Haq, launched in response to the Afghan Taliban raids.

Tarar said that 40 Afghan Taliban personnel were killed in overnight operations in the border region along the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. "Physical attack was attempted at one place,



while a fire raid was conducted on 12 locations, which were all repulsed without any loss of life," he said in an update posted on X. "At least 40 Afghan Taliban were killed in the overnight operations in KP," he said,

adding that "follow-up" operations continued.

Separately, the Afghan Taliban resorted to physical attack from across the border on 16 locations in Northern Balochistan in Qilla Saifullah, Noshki and Chaman districts

while engaging Pakistan troops on 25 locations in a fire raid. "The attacks at all the locations were repulsed with Afghan Taliban suffering 27 killed and scores injured," he said. The minister also said that one soldier of

the paramilitary Frontier Corps Balochistan North was killed while five soldiers were injured. Minister said in a statement that Pakistani security forces killed 435 Afghan Taliban combatants and another 630 of them were injured. He said that 188 tanks were destroyed, 31 Afghan posts were captured and 51 locations across Afghanistan were successfully targeted in air strikes.

Pakistan armed forces successfully conducted an air operation in Afghanistan's Nangarhar province, destroying the Khogani base. "Fitna al-Khawarij and Taliban face massive setbacks on every front after unprovoked aggression," PTV reported, citing sources. (PTI)

Texas shooting: FBI probes extremist links

SEEMA HAKHU KACHRU
■ Houston

A 21-year-old Indian-American student is among four killed in a shooting outside a bar in Austin that is being investigated as a possible act of terrorism. Savitha Shan, an Austin native and a dual-degree senior at the University of Texas at Austin, was fatally shot when a gunman opened fire in a crowded entertainment district on West Sixth Street on Sunday.

She was months away from graduation and was described by university officials as an outstanding



student leader studying management information systems and economics. The identities of the two persons who died at the scene of the shooting have been confirmed by Chief Lisa Davis of the Austin police at a news conference on Monday afternoon. (AP)

Melania will preside at UN meeting on children in conflict as US attacks Iran

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ United Nations

US first lady Melania Trump will preside over a UN Security Council meeting on Monday that will focus on children in conflict, one of her signature issues, at a turbulent time as the United States has joined Israel in attacking Iran.

The UN says she will be the first spouse of a world leader to take the president's seat at the United Nations' most powerful body, which is charged with ensuring global peace and security.

The wife of President Donald Trump was given the opportunity as the



Melania Trump presides over a United Nations Security Council meeting at United Nations headquarters AP

United States takes over the council presidency for the month of March. In the past, presidents, prime ministers and foreign ministers have often wielded the gavel. The rotating president of the 15-member council gets

to choose the subject and participants for some meetings. Monday's meeting, which was scheduled before the war began on Saturday, is officially titled "Children, Technology, and Education in Conflict." The first lady's office

said it will "emphasise education's role in advancing tolerance and world peace." Melania Trump will be watched for anything she says, or doesn't say, about the impact on children of the war her husband is waging.

Iranian state media has reported that a girls' school in southern Iran was hit in an airstrike on Saturday, killing at least 165 people and wounding dozens more.

The Israeli military said it was not aware of strikes in the area. The US military said it was looking into the reports. The council's last meeting, on Saturday, was a contentious emergency session called in response to the war.

Court rejects US administration attempt to slow tariff refund process



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

A federal court rejected the Trump administration's attempt to slow the process of refunding billions of dollars' worth of tariffs the Supreme Court struck down as illegal last month.

The US Court of Appeals for the Federal Circuit started the next phase in the refund process by sending it to a lower court to sort out.

In a court filing Friday, Trump's Justice Department had urged the Federal Circuit to proceed cautiously and hold off for 90 days. But the judges refused.

The Supreme Court ruled Feb 20 that Trump's sweeping tariffs on most countries in the world were illegal, clearing the way for the importers who paid them to seek refunds.

The Government had collected more than \$130 billion from the tariffs by mid-December, and could ultimately be on the hook for refunds worth \$175 billion, according to calculations by the Penn Wharton Budget Model.

Nepal election: 18.9 million registered voters cast to votes on 5 March

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kathmandu

Nepal is holding parliamentary elections on Thursday, a year after a youth-led uprising forced out the government chosen in the last elections.

The election is being held just three years after Nepal's previous national vote, following the political upheaval that led to the government's collapse in 2025.

That paved the way for an interim government, which later called for fresh elections. Nearly 19 million people are registered to vote in Nepal, according to the Election Commission. About 966,000 are men and



Nepal Police temporary personnel stand guard at a polling station at Arunodaya Basic School in Kathmandu PTI

924,000 are women. Another 200 voters are registered under the "others" category, which includes people who do not identify as male or female and members of the LGBTQ+ community.

The number of registered voters has risen by nearly 1 million since the last parliamentary election in November 2022, as the youth-led uprising sparked greater interest in politics. The voting age in Nepal is 18, and authorities had urged eligible young adults to register.

The youth-led uprising in September 2025 that brought down the previous government and triggered early elections has become a defining issue in the cam-

paign. Political parties have vowed to amplify the voices of younger voters, promising to tackle corruption and improve governance.

Voters will directly elect 165 members to the House of Representatives, the powerful lower chamber of Parliament.

The remaining 110 seats in the 275-member House will be filled through a proportional representation system, with political parties nominating lawmakers based on the share of votes each party receives.

Previous government in Nepal have largely been coalitions, with two or more parties joining forces to

command a majority in the House. The country has a history of political instability, having seen 15 governments in the past two decades.

The Nepali Congress and the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) are the long-dominant political parties. However, they had been part of the government ousted last year and have faced public dissatisfaction.

The National Independent Party, formed in 2022, has drawn significant support on the campaign trail. Former Kathmandu Mayor Balendra Shah, also an ex-rapper, is its candidate for prime minister.

PROSPECT



On the occasion Douh Mahotsav, Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma visited the revered birthplace of Gurujona Mahapurush Srimanta Sankardev at Sri Sri Batadrava Than in Nagaon and offered prayers

CGST Gurugram busts fake GST registration racket

The Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST), Gurugram conducted coordinated search proceedings at multiple premises in North Delhi in connection with an investigation into a large-scale fake GST registration racket, an official said on Tuesday.

According to an official statement, a fake GST registration racket was being operated by means of taking registrations using forged documents. These documents were thereafter misused for obtaining GST registrations of fake firms without the knowledge of the unsuspecting individuals. Thus far investigation has revealed that 24 fake firms falling under the CGST Gurugram jurisdiction were created using the same modus operandi. These firms collectively generated fraudulent invoices amounting to ₹734.95 crore, leading to fraudulent availment of ITC amounting to ₹143.05 crore and passing on of ITC amounting to ₹174.72 crore. Investigation has further identified that the accused had applied for registration of 1,400 fake firms. Further investigation into the matter is underway.

Coordinated search proceedings were conducted at multiple premises in Burari, Swarop Nagar and Mukundpur areas of North Delhi, and one key individual was arrested on Monday under the provisions of the CGST Act, 2017. The JMFC Court, Gurugram, viewing the seriousness of the offence, sent the accused person to judicial custody for three days, he added. Tracking of IP addresses used to take GST registration led to the identification of various premises, wherein, during search, incriminating evidence was seized, including mobile phones, laptops, documents and SIM cards.

Haryana farmers get One-Stop agriculture resource hub

In a collaborative effort with the Haryana Government and ICAR-Central Soil Salinity Research Institute (CSSRI), a new Agriculture Technology Information and Farmers Resource Centre has been set up at CSSRI Karnal. New facility offers a single-window platform providing authentic information on soil health, salinity management, water conservation, pest resistance, climate-smart practices, digital tools and Government schemes. Speaking at the inauguration, Susheel Kumar, Managing Director and Country Head, Syngenta India, said the centre will guide farmers on soil health card analysis, safe spraying practices, product authenticity and market trends while creating awareness about under-utilised state and central schemes.A major focus is on rural youth. Recognising rising migration, the centre will impart drone piloting and spraying skills under the flagship programme. Participants receive one-month classroom training followed by two-month field exposure and support to secure jobs or start agri-ventures.The initiative builds on the October 29, 2024 MoU with CSSRI for joint research, field demonstrations and capacity building in saline areas.



DABUR RÉAL LAUNCHES 'REAL WALE RANG SAB PE CHADH JAAYE' CAMPAIGN FOR HOLI

"New Delhi, March 03, 2026:" Dabur India Limited has launched its Holi campaign, "Real Wale Rang Sab Pe Chadh Jaaye", positioning Réal Fruit Power as the ideal hydration and energy companion for the festival. The vibrant initiative celebrates the uninhibited joy of Holi and encourages consumers to embrace their authentic "Rangbaaz" spirit while staying energized with fruit nutrition. The campaign features a high-energy musical film blending tradition, friendship, and spontaneous celebration. Mr. Mayank Kumar, Vice President-Marketing, said the campaign highlights Holi as an explosion of energy best enjoyed by being one's true self, supported by Réal Fruit Power's nutrition and hydration. Ms. Monisha Prasher, GM-Marketing (Foods), added that the brand aims to power a "No Filter" Holi while remaining a trusted refreshment partner for Indian households.

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1.	For Verka Mohali Dairy i. Flex & Glow Sign Boards, Banners, stickers and other advertisement material etc. ii. Hiring of insulated vehicles of minimum 01 MT capacity for 2 nd leg delivery of Verka Milk and Milk products in Delhi-NCR area.	Annual 03 No's (no. of vehicles may increased or decreased)

NOTE:

1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

General Manager (Purchase)

1018/12/2025-26/9047

Indian Army celebrates Holi at children home in Assam



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

On 3 March 2026, the Red Shield Gunners, under the aegis of Spear Corps, filled the children home at Rupai, Assam, with vibrant hues and heartfelt smiles as they celebrated the festival of colours with the resident children as part of their continued community outreach initiatives. "Colours of joy flooded the orphanage" as soldiers and children came together in a

celebration marked not only by colours and sweets, but by genuine affection and shared laughter. A total of 20 children, aged between 8 and 17 years, participated enthusiastically, their excitement lighting up the entire premises. The celebrations began with the spread of colours, soon turning into moments of carefree fun and joyous interaction. Army personnel spent meaningful time with the children—playing, talking, encouraging and listening—



ensuring that each child felt valued and embraced. The festival became a symbol of warmth and belonging, where uniforms blended with vibrant colours and hearts connected beyond barriers. During the interaction, the significance of Holi as a festival of unity, hope and positivity was shared, reinforcing values of harmony and togetherness. Sweets were distributed to all, adding sweetness to the day and strengthening the bond between the Indian Army and the local community. The smiles, laughter and shining faces of the children reflected the true essence of Holi—spreading love, sharing happiness and standing together as one extended family. The initiative reaffirmed the Indian Army's steadfast commitment to community welfare, youth engagement and nurturing bonds of trust with the people of Assam.

Himanta inaugurates Kaziranga Orchid Park having 900 indigenous species

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Tuesday inaugurated a park, showcasing over 900 indigenous orchid species, in Kaziranga area. He said the project, situated at Kohora in Golaghat district, will give a boost to the state's eco-tourism and cultural landscape. In a post on X, Sarma said, "Unlike the Cong Govt, we don't just promise, WE DELIVER. In 2021, I mentioned our plans to set up an Orchid Park in Kaziranga. Today, in

2026, I am glad to have inaugurated this park, which will house over 1,600 varieties of orchids and will be a major tourist attraction." Sarma tagged his post on X from May 22, 2021, when he mentioned the highlights of then-Fovernor Jagdish Mukhi's speech in the state assembly's first sitting after the BJP leader became the chief minister. In the section on 'agriculture', Sarma had said the governor announced setting up an orchid park in Kaziranga, among other highlights.



Telcos gross revenue crosses ₹1 lakh cr in December qtr, AGR up 8.13% to ₹84,270 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The cumulative gross revenue of telecom service providers crossed the ₹1 lakh crore mark in the December 2025 quarter to ₹1.02 lakh crore, according to a report by sector regulator Trai, published on Tuesday. The gross revenue of telecom service providers (TSPs) was ₹96,390 crore a year ago and ₹99,828 crore in the September 2025 quarter. The adjusted gross revenue (AGR) grew by 8.13 per cent on a year-over-year basis to ₹84,270 crore in the December 2025 quarter, from ₹77,934 crore in the same period a year ago. The adjusted gross revenue (AGR) is derived from the sale of telecom services and Government levies, including licence fees and spectrum usage charges. Access service providers, which are players like Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel,



Vodafone Idea, etc, accounted for 84.54 per cent of total AGR in the December 2025 quarter. The AGR data published till the September 2025 quarter by the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) in the performance indicator report shows that Reliance Jio topped the chart with revenue of ₹31,767.11 crore. It was followed by Bharti Airtel with an AGR of ₹28,497.45 crore, Vodafone Idea with ₹8,176.62 crore.

Yaoshang celebration with locals organised by army at Ningthoukhong in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Indian Army personnel celebrated Yaoshang with the local community at Ningthoukhong, fostering a spirit of unity, harmony and cultural bonding. The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from villagers, youth and women from villages of Kwasiphai, Nachou, Bishnupur, Kha potshangbam, Upopki, Taubul and Khoijuman.

As part of the celebrations, a 10 km run was organised for both male and female participants, promoting physical fitness, sportsmanship and community participation. The run saw energetic involvement from local youth who participated with great enthusiasm. In addition, a Tug-of-War competition was organised for the Meira Paibis, encouraging teamwork and friendly competition among the participants. The event created a festive atmosphere, with locals and soldiers celebrating the spirit



of Yaoshang together. The event reflected Indian Army's continued commitment to strengthening ties with local communities and promoting social harmony through sports and cultural engagement. Participants appreciated the effort, which provided a platform for interaction,

recreation and community bonding. Such activities by the Indian Army continue to reinforce mutual trust and cooperation between the security forces and the people of Manipur, while celebrating the vibrant traditions and festivals of the region.

GST fraud racket busted in Kanpur, ₹250 cr transactions detected; 2 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanpur

The Kanpur police have unearthed an organised GST fraud racket in which the accused allegedly used identity documents of poor and unsuspecting individuals to float fake firms and route transactions worth nearly ₹250 crore, a senior official said on Tuesday. Two people have been arrested while five others are absconding, they said, adding that the fraud appears to be part of a wider inter-state tax evasion network. The arrested accused have been identified as Kapil Mishra and Amardeep alias Raj. Addressing a press conference, Police Commissioner Raghubir Lal said the gang targeted e-rickshaw drivers,



students and economically weaker persons by luring them with promises of easy loans. "The accused collected PAN, Aadhaar and signed documents on the pretext of arranging loans. These were later misused to register fake firms, obtain GST numbers and open bank accounts to commit large-scale Input Tax Credit (ITC) fraud," he said. The racket came to light after a resident of the

Nazirabad area, Anurag Verma, complained that documents he had submitted while seeking a loan for his sister's wedding were being misused. A probe by the Cyber Cell revealed that a company had been registered in his name without his knowledge and financial transactions were being carried out through it. Technical investigation involving bank account analysis, call detail records and digital transaction tracking exposed a structured network operating multiple shell companies using stolen identities. In one case, police traced transactions worth ₹117 crore to a bank account opened in the name of Ujjawal Gupta, son of an e-rickshaw driver from neighbouring Unnao district.

War risk insurance premiums for ships likely to rise amid West Asia crisis: Experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Freight carriers will have to pay an additional premium to restore war cover for shipments passing through high-risk areas amid the escalating crisis in West Asia, experts said. Vessels of the Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) are also involved in the movement of crude oil and LNG, especially through areas around the Red Sea, and

panies may adjust pricing quickly based on the risk level. Since cargo insurance premium is calculated based on cargo value, the total premium amount may go up, even if the rate stays the same," he said. However, he said, unless the conflict becomes long and widespread, a major overall increase in insurance premiums across the board is unlikely. Experts further said shipment or cargoes that have

Reportedly, rates have gone up to 1 per cent from 0.25 per cent to 0.5 per cent, and this will significantly increase shipping costs and disrupt global trade flows, he added. In aviation, hull war risk (HWR) coverage for airline fleets is expected to see sharp rate increases and potential reductions in underwriting capacity, he said, adding that airlines may require Government-backed reinsurance support to maintain



would have to pay an additional premium for war cover to ensure risk cover. "It is reasonable to expect that Indian oil companies will have cargo exposures and SCI will have hull exposure in this region. Oil prices are also likely to face upward pressure in the near term," Policybazaar Head (marine insurance) Balasundaram R said. According to Prudent Insurance Brokers Head (marine specialties), Gaurav Agarwal, notice of cancellation of war cover has been issued on hull on March 1, and a similar cancellation on cargo is expected soon. After this cancellation, Agarwal said, the insurers may increase premiums on hull and cargo. "If the conflict becomes a serious war risk, insurance premiums for ships are likely to go up, and insurance com-

already sailed from India are anchoring in international waters, are waiting for the situation to ease out, and alternate routes are being worked on by shipping lines, which will add additional cost to the importer/exporter. Heightened geopolitical tensions in the Persian Gulf have resulted in the withdrawal of war risk coverage for marine insurance, Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBAI) expert Hari Radhakrishnan said. "Under marine insurance policies, war and SRCC (Strikes, Riots, and Civil Commotion) coverage is typically subject to 3 days or seven days' notice of cancellation. Once cancelled, fresh war risk cover may become unavailable - or, where still offered, priced at prohibitively high levels," Radhakrishnan said.

operations, similar to the sovereign guarantee Israel has extended to its national carriers against war-related losses. Beyond marine and aviation lines, he said, the conflict is likely to create knock-on effects across other classes of insurance. "Travel and event insurance will be directly affected by restrictions on movement and heightened cancellation risks. Broader economic consequences - including inflation, supply chain disruptions, and shortages of materials and labor - could drive up claims costs across multiple lines," he said. Additionally, he said, volatility in global financial markets may pressure insurers' investment portfolios, further affecting profitability and capital adequacy.

BRIEFLY

Vaishnavi Adkar in Indian team for Billie Jean King Cup



Promising Vaishnavi Adkar was on Tuesday drafted into the Indian team for the Billie Jean King Cup Asia/Oceania Group I tie, to be held here from April 6. The 21-year-old Adkar recently made history in Bengaluru, becoming the first Indian woman to reach the W100 final since Sania Mirza. Adkar had also bagged the Ahmedabad W15 title in 2024, signalling her steady rise through the ranks. Apart from Adkar, India has fielded seasoned Sahaja Yamalapalli and Shrivalli Bhamidipaty along with Rutuja Bhosale and Ankita Raina. Vaidehee Chaudhari has been named as the reserve. "A Coaching Camp will be held one week before the event. Vishal Uppal will be the Captain and Radhika Kanitkar will be the coach of the Indian Team," the All India Tennis Association (AITA) said in a release.

I am back home: Sindhu lands in Bengaluru from Dubai



Two-time Olympic medal-winning Indian badminton star P V Sindhu, who was stranded in Dubai due to closure of airspace in the Gulf region, has returned to the country after pulling out of the All England Championships in Birmingham. Sindhu posted on X to announce that she is back in the city. "Back home in Bangalore and safe. The last few days have been intense and uncertain, but I'm truly grateful to be back to my house," she posted. "A heartfelt thank you to the incredible ground teams, Dubai authorities, airport staff, immigration, and every single person who stepped up and took such good care of us during a very difficult time. The empathy and professionalism meant more than words can say. "For now, it's time to rest, reset, and figure out the next steps," she added. The former world champion was on her way to Birmingham via Dubai, when she was stranded after the flight operations were suspended in the Gulf region following the US and Israeli bombing of Iran. Iran subsequently retaliated, hitting Dubai as well. "Moments like these remind you how fragile normal life really is," she had posted on February 28 while revealing some details of her ordeal, which included an explosion near her place of stay. She had described the experience as "extremely tense and scary moment" for her and her team, including Indonesian coach Irwansyah Adi Pratama.

Star-studded field to feature in Sunil Gavaskar's DP World Celebrity Golf Event

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

A glittering array of stars from sporting fraternity such as cricket World Cup winners Yuvraj Singh and Eoin Morgan, tennis legend Leander Paes and badminton great Prakash Padukone will feature in the DP World Celebrity Golf Event, a charity initiative conceptualised by batting legend Sunil Gavaskar. The event, which is scheduled to take place at the iconic Bombay Presidency Golf Club on Friday, aims to create awareness for the CHAMPS Foundation, founded by Gavaskar to support former Indian international athletes facing financial hardship and medical challenges.

Since its inception, the CHAMPS Foundation has played a vital role in providing dignity, care, and assistance to sporting heroes who have represented India. The event will feature an elite list of over 100 participants competing across an 18-hole course. The participants include prominent Indian cricketers like Yuvraj, GR Vishwanath, Venkatesh Prasad, Harbhajan Singh, Ajay Jadeja, Parthiv Patel, Murali Kartik, S Badrinath, Murali Vijay and Nikhil Chopra along side international cricketers like Morgan, Michael Vaughan and David Lloyd. The event will also feature

India to face Vietnam in AFC Asian Cup opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Perth

The lack of international game time could haunt India when they face higher-ranked Vietnam in their opening group match of the AFC Women's Asian Cup football tournament here on Wednesday. Ranked lowest in the group of four teams, the others being Japan and Chinese Taipei, India has not played a single international match this year. The last time they played an international match was in October 2025, against Iran and Nepal, which they lost 0-2 and 1-2, respectively. Instead of playing international matches, India opted to



play against club sides during a four-week camp in Turkiye, from where the Blue Tigresses arrived in Perth on February 11. Since then, the Indian team played friendly matches against two Australian club

sides. There was a November FIFA international match window, but India did not play any matches. Amelia Valverde, Costa Rica's head coach at the 2015 and 2023 FIFA Women's World Cups, took charge only in January

after Crispin Chhetri, who is currently assistant coach, was at the helm during the qualification round. Vietnam, on the other hand, have played four international matches in February, two each against Uzbekistan and China, both strong sides in the continent, winning once and losing thrice. Ranked 36 in the FIFA list, as against 67 for India, Vietnam's women's team has been a rising force, having qualified for the 2023 FIFA Women's World Cup. They also reached the quarter-finals of the previous edition of the Asian Cup. Vietnam have also won both their previous clashes against India in the AFC Women's Asian Cup, both in

MIX OF EXPERIENCE AND NEW FACES

The Indian squad of 26 has six uncapped players. Eight of them were part of the last Asian Cup that was hosted by India in 2022 -- Sweety Devi Ngangbam, Shilky Devi Hemam, Sanju, Anju Tamang, Pyari Xaxa, Grace Dangmei, Manisha Kalyan and Sowmiya Narayanasamy. India withdrew from the 2022 tournament after just one game due to a COVID outbreak despite staying inside a bio-secure bubble in Mumbai. That team of 2022 had stalwarts in Ashalata Devi, Aditi Chauhan and Ratanbala Devi, who have not all been in the scheme of things for some time. Grace Dangmei is the highest-capped player and top-scorer in India's squad with 23 goals in 91 appearances. Just like in the 2022 edition squad, the 20-year-old Shilky Devi Hemam is the youngest in the Indian squad. Midfielder Anju Tamang, the senior-most player in the squad, was ruled out of the tournament due to an injury a few days back, and Karishma Shirvoikar has been drafted in.

the group stage, scoring multiple goals on both occasions (3-0 and 2-1). However, this will

be the first meeting between the two sides in the competition since 2003.

Indian women's team rues lack of playing kits ahead of AFC Asian Cup

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ New Delhi

In an embarrassing development that exposed mismanagement within the All India Football Federation (AIFF), national team players complained about a lack of appropriate clothing during preparation and the arrival of ill-fitting kits just a day before their opening AFC Women's Asian Cup match in Australia. In an unprecedented letter addressed to AIFF Deputy General Secretary M Satyanarayanan ahead of India's opening match against Vietnam in Perth on Wednesday, all 26 players of the squad expressed their frustration at the lack of proper clothing and playing kits, saying it has affected

their morale and disrupted their focus. "Representing India on the international stage requires professional standards, including properly fitted and appropriate match and training apparel," the letter said, clearly suggesting a lack of professionalism in the AIFF management. "Over the past few days, players and staff have already faced challenges due to the lack of appropriate clothing during preparation. The arrival of incorrect match kits at this crucial stage has further affected morale and disrupted our focus in the final days leading up to the match." The letter was signed by eight players, including captain Sweety Devi Ngangbam and highest



capped member Grace Dangmei, but said all the members of the squad collectively agreed to its contents. The letter also listed all 26 players who have agreed to the contents. "This internal meeting took place on 2nd March at 2:00 pm between all the players. The decision to draft this letter is collective. The meeting was headed by the

following players: Sweety Devi, Manisha Kalyan, Grace Dangmei, Sangita Basfore, Panthoi Chanu, Sanju, Pyari Xaxa, Shreya Hooda," the letter said. The AIFF, on its part, said new kits have been provided to the players on Tuesday. "New kits provided and cleared in this morning's match commissioners meeting of the AFC,"

Cyclist Kanthi Dutt to go on 750km tour to promote 'Fit India'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Cyclist Kanthi Dutt, who is also a Sports Authority of India (SAI) fitness ambassador, will embark on a 750km road tour from Hyderabad to Mumbai to promote the government's flagship 'Fit India' campaign, starting March 7. Dutt is an ultra-endurance cyclist and took to the sport to rebuild himself psychologically after the death of his father. "Fitness did not just make me fitter. It helped me heal emotionally. It helped me find myself again. That is what I want people to understand. This is about inner health, not just the physical," Dutt stated in a press release as he spoke about the



planned journey, which will culminate on March 14. "Hyderabad to Mumbai. My first tour. I want it to stand for something, for every person who has ever felt stuck, or afraid, or like they have lost their way.

You can find yourself again. I did," he added. The ride has the support of SAI and aligns with the Fit India initiative. "The initiative will be carried out through mass outreach, interactive ses-

sions, and meet-and-greet programmes at various educational institutions en route, including universities and colleges across Telangana, Karnataka and Maharashtra," SAI Deputy Director General Mayank Srivastava stated in a letter to Dutt. "Fit India is pleased to acknowledge your continued association as a Fit India Ambassador and appreciates your efforts in undertaking this impactful outreach...and inspire citizens to adopt cycling and active living as part of their daily lives," he added. The journey will begin at Novotel HICC, Hyderabad, on March 7. On March 12, a milestone celebration will mark 500 kilometres completed on the road in Pune.

West Indies team stranded in India due to airspace restrictions



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The West Indies cricket team's departure from India after its exit from the T20 World Cup has been delayed owing to international airspace restrictions triggered by the US and Israeli strikes on Iran. Cricket West Indies said it is working closely with the ICC and relevant Government authorities for ensure safe travel of the players. Flight operations in the Gulf region are currently suspended with damage also reported at the Dubai International Airport, which is one the busiest in the world. "Cricket West Indies (CWI) wishes to advise that the departure of the West Indies Senior Men's Team from India, following their exit from the ICC Men's T20 World Cup, has been delayed due to international airspace restrictions," the board said in a statement. "These restrictions are a direct result of the security threats posed by military action in the Gulf Region, which has impacted several international flight routes and required airlines to adjust scheduled services for safety reasons." The team

lost to India in a must-win Super Eight match in Kolkata to bow out of the tournament. "CWI appreciates the understanding and concern of our fans, families, and stakeholders during this time," the statement added. Besides West Indies, Zimbabwe is also stranded in India due to the same reason. Zimbabwe Cricket confirmed on Monday that the squad remains in Delhi, adding that while fresh travel arrangements are being worked out. "The squad was scheduled to return home via Dubai, but travel plans have been affected by the evolving situation in the Middle East, which has disrupted key transit routes," Zimbabwe cricket said in a statement on 'X'. The ICC has activated contingency measures and is working with international carriers to secure alternative travel arrangements. "ZC remains in constant communication with the ICC and team management on the ground to ensure the squad's safe and timely return." Zimbabwe lost by five wickets to South Africa in their final Super Eights match on Sunday.



participation from distinguished athletes beyond cricket, including tennis legend Leander Paes, badminton great Prakash

Foundation was created with the belief that those who have brought glory to India through sport should never be left behind in times of need. This event is not just about golf, it is about giving back to the sporting community that has given us so much," Gavaskar said. "I am deeply grateful to DP World and all the participating legends who have come forward to support this cause. Their presence reflects the strong sense of camaraderie and responsibility that defines the global sporting fraternity," he said. "I thought that, you know, that while there are so many foundations, so many charities for education, for child welfare, for women, for, you

know, for medical, for nutrition, so many, you know, foundations and charities which look after all that, but there was nothing for former Indian international sports persons. And that's how the idea came to me," he added earlier during a select media interaction. Indian tennis legend Paes added, "Sport teaches us resilience, discipline, and the importance of standing by one another. The CHAMPS Foundation embodies these very values. It's inspiring to see athletes across disciplines unite to support fellow sportspersons. "This event is a celebration of sport's enduring spirit and a reminder that the sporting community is, above all, a family."

Fiorentina, Pisa lose fighting Serie A relegation

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Pisa (Italy)

Fiorentina went down to Udinese 3-0, and Pisa lost to Bologna 1-0 on an unhappy night for the relegation-threatened sides in Serie A. In Udine, the home side went ahead after 10 minutes when Christian Kabasele nodded in a Nicolo Zaniolo corner. Udinese's leading goal-scorer, Kelman Davis, made it 2-0 from the penalty spot in the second half. And Adam Buksa added a third in stoppage time to decisively halt Fiorentina's recent revival and torpedo its hopes of winning three games in a row for the first time this season. It remained fifth from bottom of the



league, but equal on points with Cremonese and Lecce, the club occupying the third

relegation spot. One of the two teams below it, Pisa, lost at home to

Bologna and remained joint last with Verona. Pisa had three shots on target while Bologna had only one, but it was that 90th-minute strike from Jens Odgaard that decided the match. The Danish forward hit the net from around 25 meters out to break the home fans' hearts and ensure Pisa was still looking for a second win in the league. The result leaves it on the same points as the bottom club, Verona. Both are nine points from safety with 11 league matches remaining. The win was Bologna's third in a row and lifted it above Sassuolo into ninth place. It has not lost a league game at home to Pisa since February 1985.

Real Madrid lose second straight, miss chance to close gap on Liga leader Barcelona

JOHN MARSHALLAP
■ Madrid

Real Madrid lost a second straight La Liga match when a stunning volley from Martin Satriano gave Getafe a shock 1-0 win at Santiago Bernabeu Stadium on Monday. The result prevented the capital club from cutting the four-point gap to leader Barcelona. Getafe had lost all eight of its previous league encounters with Real Madrid and early saves from goalkeeper David Soria kept it from falling behind. Soria turned over a shot from Arda Guler midway through the first half, not long after frustrating Vinicius



Junior when he was through on goal. Madrid had more of the ball but lacked punch up front and it paid a price for its profligacy six minutes before halftime when Getafe took the lead. A hopeful cross from the right was headed clear but it fell to the feet of Satriano,

who volleyed into the roof of the net from 20 meters out. It was the second goal in three games for the Uruguayan, who joined on loan from Lyon during the last transfer window. Madrid continued to dominate possession in the second half and Antonio

Rudiger and substitute Rodrygo were among those who came close to grabbing an equalizer. But it could not find a way past Getafe's stuffy rear-guard and an in-form Soria. Madrid's task became even harder when Franco Mastantuono was sent off for dissent in stoppage time and although the numbers were evened up in the last minute when Getafe's Adrian Liso was also shown a red card it came too late to make any impact. Getafe held on to secure a historic win, its first at the Santiago Bernabeu since 2008, and a vital three points in its bid to stay in La Liga. (AP)

‘Hoping for a perfect win against India’

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

Set for a third consecutive semifinal clash at the T20 World Cup, India and England won't have any secrets to throw at each other here on Thursday, said Sam Curran, hoping for his side to pull off a 'perfect game' after a topsy-turvy campaign so far.

India and England have each won one of those semi-finals and then gone on to lift the T20 World Cup. While England clinched the trophy after crushing India by 10 wickets in the 2022 edition, India claimed their second title in 2024 after a 78-run win in 2024.

'It's just nice having played at the ground many times, so there aren't many unknowns for us,' Curran told reporters here ahead of England's training session on Tuesday at the Wankhede Stadium.

'We've got two days training now, so we'll get used to the surroundings, the change room, and (the) dimensions of the ground...things like that. You play (at) these stadiums so much, you get used to different conditions.

'The crowd, the opposition, we play a lot with the Indian guys, so there's going to be no secrets in terms of what each team will probably throw at each other,' he added.

England have endured their fair share of ups and downs in the tournament, including a nervy four-run win over minnows Nepal. In the Super Eight stage, their two-wicket victory over Pakistan was largely thanks to the individual brilliance of



Harry Brook, who struck an epic hundred.

'It doesn't really matter now; it comes down to the World Cup semifinal. If there's ever a time we want to play our perfect game, it's probably Thursday night,' Curran said.

'We've all been chipping in at different times, but we know in T20 cricket it probably just takes a couple of our guys to come good with the bat and good with the ball.'

Wankhede is expected to be packed loudest for India on Thursday, and Curran knows how 'quiet' it would be in what is expected to be a high-scoring contest.

'It's a fantastic stadium, obviously very iconic. I'm sure it's going to be very quiet on Thursday night,' Curran said with a smile.

'As a young cricketer, you

dream of playing in a semifinal of the World Cup. It's normally a pretty good wicket, small ground, so I'm probably expecting a really high-scoring game,' he added.

Despite the defending champions' confident campaign so far, Curran said his side won't be intimidated.

'India is a quality side, but we've played a lot of cricket here. Most of our (players in the) team have played in the IPL and against India. We're not fearing anything, and I'm sure both teams are really excited by the challenge of Thursday night, and hopefully, the perfect game for us happens,' he continued.

Three of the four semifinalists in this edition are from outside the Indian subcontinent, and Curran said it is down to adaptability.

'This tournament for us has been a little bit of a challenge in terms of (how) we've come across so many different conditions, playing in Sri Lanka and obviously a couple of games here and in Kolkata,' Curran said.

'We've adapted extremely well. You'd probably say that the non-subcontinental teams have adapted really well to, I guess, the conditions thrown at them.'

And major credit for it goes to the melting pot that is the IPL.

'All of us play a lot of cricket in India now, so we know how to play on these grounds, and we know what to expect, and the IPL, no question, has helped a lot of that with the players.

'South Africa and New Zealand are fantastic teams, and we're a really good

team as well. And of course, India. I think probably the four best teams are in the semifinals and we'll see who takes that trophy,' Curran added.

It was here at the Wankhede Stadium in February last year when India and England faced off in a T20I, a contest which is remembered for world No.1 Abhishek Sharma's 54-ball 135, laden with 13 sixes and seven boundaries.

As pressure to get big runs mounts on a currently struggling Abhishek, Curran hoped history wouldn't repeat itself.

'I do hope Abhishek doesn't have the same knock again. We're very well-planned for the game, and we keep the focus on Thursday night,' Curran added. (PTI)

Can Jos Buttler end his lean run in recent ICC events at Wankhede

BHARAT SHARMA ■ Mumbai

Runs have dried up from Jos Buttler's bat at ICC events of late, but England are banking on their white-ball great to play a match-winning knock against India in the second T20 World Cup semifinal here on Thursday.

Buttler endured a forgettable ODI World Cup in India back in 2023, and nothing has gone to plan so far in the T20 World Cup for the 35-year-old in a country where he has scored tons of runs in the IPL, including the 2025 edition.

England is not worried about his form, but to put his lean run in perspective, he has only managed a single fifty-plus score in his last four ICC events, including the 2023 ODI World Cup, the 2024 T20 World Cup and the Champions Trophy last year.

The pitches, which have been on the slower side in this event, especially in Sri Lanka, have also not aided his style of play.

Two days from the semifinal at Wankhede, Buttler had an hour-long net session where he tried to find his groove against the spinners.

Adil Rashid, Will Jacks and Liam Dawson provided good practice to the out-of-form opener who may well rediscover his mojo at a ground he is very familiar with.

He attempted slog sweeps off Rashid, targeted the straight boundary against left-arm spinner



Dawson and sent the ball to the cow corner region when Jacks rolled his arm over.

After facing the England spinners, Buttler moved to the other side of the main square to face throwdowns.

Ahead of the training session, all-rounder Sam Curran backed his close friend to come good against India.

'Jos is someone I'm pretty close to. He obviously wants more runs. But I certainly would rather have Jos Buttler in my team than coming up against him on Thursday night. I think he's such a quality player. He's done so well for us over many, many years.

'And he's done well on this ground many, many times as well. So hopefully Thursday night is his night. But if it's not, there's no question he's one of the

best in the world.

'So he and Salty (Phil), such a dangerous opening partnership. And I guess we hope Thursday night they can get us off to a really good start. There's no doubt that he'll come good and we're not worried about him at all,' added Curran.

Curran's comments echoed the views of his teammates, including Captain Harry Brook, who feels Buttler is in a bit of a rut, but it is only a matter of time before he fires.

'There's been a lot said about Jos. I said the other day that he's played 150 (154) games for England (in T20Is), and people probably need to take a little step back from that. He's probably the best white-ball player to have ever played the game. (PTI)

Gaffaney, Palekar to referee India-England T20 WC semis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

New Zealand's Chris Gaffaney and Allahuddin Palekar of South Africa will be the on-field umpires for the T20 World Cup semifinal between India and England in Mumbai on Thursday, with Zimbabwean Andy Pycroft as match referee.

The ICC on Tuesday announced the match officials of the semifinals of the T20 World Cup ahead of the knockout fixtures in Kolkata and Mumbai.

Gaffaney also oversaw the proceedings when India and England met at the same stage in the 2024 edition of the tournament. Palekar, on the other hand, stood in two of England's matches in the ongoing tournament as well as India's victory over the Netherlands.

Accompanying the trio in Mumbai will be Adrian Holdstock (third umpire) and Paul Reiffel (fourth umpire).



The English duo of Richard Illingworth and Alex Wharf will be assuming the role of on-field umpires in the first semifinal between South Africa and New Zealand at the Eden Gardens on Wednesday.

The pair will be joined in Kolkata by Nitin Menon as third umpire, while Rod Tucker will take his place as the fourth umpire. Javagal Srinath has been named the match referee for this game.

Illingworth was also among the on-field umpires for South Africa's T20 World Cup semifinal two years ago against Afghanistan.

Give Bumrah at least two overs in powerplay: Gavaskar

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

The tussle between Harry Brook and Jasprit Bumrah will shape the outcome of India's T20 World Cup semifinal clash against England, batting legend Sunil Gavaskar has predicted while urging the home side to give its pace spearhead at least two overs in the powerplay.

Reigning champions India will take on England at the Wankhede Stadium in Mumbai on Thursday in a repeat of the semifinal matches in the 2022 and 2024 editions.

'I do believe that he (Bumrah) should be bowling at least two overs in the powerplay because as a new-ball bowler, if he can get those early wickets... Jos Buttler, Phil Salt and Harry Brook, he will have pretty much broken the back of the England batting,' Gavaskar told select media ahead of DP World Celebrity Golf Event to create awareness about the CHAMPS Foundation.

Bumrah has been mostly

bowling one over during the powerplay, with the team saving at least two of his overs at the death. However, in the lost Super Eight game against South Africa, he had bowled two overs upfront.

'...him coming in to bowl the fifth over, when four overs have already been bowled, and the batters have got about 20 deliveries, means that both batters have got about 8-10 deliveries to settle in. So, wouldn't it be better than for Bumrah and for India if Bumrah were to bowl to them first and get them out?' he wondered.

Gavaskar expects the game to be a 'humdinger' with the hosts holding a slight edge because of their flexible batting unit and Bumrah.

In 2022, England subjugated India by 10 wickets at Adelaide while Rohit Sharma's team tamed the Three Lions two years later at Providence, West Indies.

'Both sides are very well-matched. They have got batting and bowling. They have got middle-order and,



you know, the finisher. Both teams have variety in their bowling,' he said.

'England have got a few players who have played in the IPL, who are familiar with Indian conditions, familiar with the pressure of playing a knockout. So, I think it is going to be a humdinger,' he added.

So, what makes Bumrah such a devastating bowler across formats? Gavaskar



cited his ability to be an enigma as a major factor.

'If you have read Andre Agassi's autobiography (Open), how did he pick up where Boris Becker was going to serve? He wasn't able to pick his serve the first few times, and then he realised that if he had his tongue on the left as he tossed the ball up, then he would be serving wide. If he had his tongue on the right, then he would be

serving on the centre line.

'But in Bumrah's case, he doesn't give you anything away. Therefore, it's very, very difficult to read him. And because he sort of goes wide and then delivers the ball, you often tend to think it's going to basically come in. But he can get the ball to move away. So that's why he's been such a devastating bowler in all three forms,' he noted.

Another advantage India has, as per Gavaskar, is a highly flexible batting unit, and he gave the example of Tilak Varma batting at various positions in this ICC showpiece.

Tilak batted at Number 3 initially, but moved down to No. 5 and 6 once the team management decided to draft in Sanju Samson into the eleven.

However, the left-hander made telling contributions in the Super Eight matches against Zimbabwe and the West Indies, guiding India to the semifinals.

'I have always thought of Tillak Varma as a very smart

cricketer, somebody who assesses the situation well and then plays accordingly. I think down the order at Number 5 or 6, he really can see what the need of the hour is. I think the way he batted (vs Windies), he really took the pressure off Samson.

'If he (Tilak) was struggling, then Samson would have had to take a few risks. In recent times, we have been told that batting order can be flexible. And I think India is fortunate to have players like Tilak who can bat at 3 or even bat at 5 or 6,' he added.

Veteran batter Jos Buttler might be struggling a bit in this tournament, but Gavaskar reminded India of the dangers of taking the Englishman lightly.

'He can be the kind of dangerous player that Abhishek Sharma is. So, I think getting Buttler's wicket early is going to be ideal. He can be, as we've seen in the IPL and in the ICC events, such a destructive batter. (PTI)

Markram vs Santner: Captains hold key to Proteas semis test vs NZ

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Kolkata

South African skipper Aiden Markram will be asked probing questions by his New Zealand counterpart Mitchell Santner in what promises to be an intriguing battle between two incredibly talented captains' in the first semifinal of the T20 World Cup on Wednesday.

Not often does one find that captains of either side end up being the most prolific performers and Markram vs Santner will be such battle that would keep the near capacity crowd at the Eden Gardens on the edge.

The ICC event rivalry between New Zealand and South Africa reached its peak during the 50-over World Cup semifinal in 2015 when the Black Caps edged out the Proteas in a nail-biting showdown with likes of Dale Steyn and AB de Villiers left scarred for life.

However, South Africa, under the tutelage of Shukri Conrad, has developed into a menacing side, having already won the World Test



Championship last year showing steely resolve.

While they haven't won a major white-ball trophy so far, the infamous chokers' tag isn't a part of their cricketing dictionary anymore.

At the core of this battle are the two captains, not often the most celebrated or talked about but tactically and technically much better than all those who are feted way more.

Markram, with a strike rate of 175 plus and 268 runs, has had a devastating effect on rival bowlers

during powerplay overs while Santner, with an economy rate of 6.35, has kept the batters tied in knots. The Proteas, with a power-hitting line-up comprising Markram, Quinton De Kock, Dewald Brevis, Ryan Rickleton, Tristan Stubbs, David Miller and Marco Jansen, can give any team sleepless nights.

But Santner will have Rachin Ravindra (9 wickets at less than 7 ER), Glenn Phillips, Cole McConchie, who have all performed in unison.

Indian women nominated for Team of the Year Award

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Madrid

In a first, the Indian women's cricket squad has been nominated for the prestigious 2026 Laureus World Team of the Year Award following their maiden World Cup title triumph. The nomination was confirmed by Laureus Sport on Tuesday.

They are the first women's cricket team to receive this nomination, a recognition for their exceptional performance in the mega event, including the highest suc-

cessful run chase in women's ODI history in a semi-final win against Australia.

The Harmanpreet Kaur-led side is nominated alongside major teams like the England Women's football team, the European Ryder Cup squad, the French football league's Paris Saint-Germain, and McLaren Formula 1.

Laureus Sport said in a press release: 'In their Cricket World Cup semi-final against Australia, the India Women's Cricket Team pulled off the highest successful run chase in women's ODI history (339)



— before winning their first title against South Africa and are the first women's cricket team to be nominated for this Award.'

The landmark triumph was celebrated nationwide, with the BCCI announcing a significant cash prize of Rs 51 crore for the squad.

Mandhana climbs to top of Women's ODI batters' rankings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India opener Smriti Mandhana on Tuesday climbed to the top of the ICC Women's ODI Batting Rankings following her fine performances in the just-concluded three-match series against Australia. Mandhana (790 points) made notable scores of 58 and 31 in the series, doing enough to move past South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt (782), who will have the opportunity to reclaim the spot when the Proteas take



on New Zealand across March and April. Making a century in her final ODI, Alyssa Healy signed off in fourth place on the rankings (744), wedged between Beth Mooney (749) and Ashleigh Gardner (724).

India captain Harmanpreet Kaur is the other Indian in top 10 in ninth position, while Jemimah Rodrigues is on 12th. Despite losing all three matches of the ODI series, there was joy for Harmanpreet (652), who moved four spots back into the top

10 for batters, thanks to scores of 53, 54 and 25. Deepti Sharma is the lone Indian in top 10 among bowlers at the 10th spot. Alana King (775) jumped to the top of Women's ODI bowling rankings, ending Sophie Ecclestone's near four-year reign at the top of the rankings. Gardner is placed third. Across the week King led both the teams with seven wickets at an average of 16.71, claiming 4/33 from 10 overs in the third ODI, helping the hosts to a 185-run victory.